TWCF Request for Ideas

Character Virtue Development — Submitted February 13, 2026

BASIC INFORMATION

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GROUP OR CONSORTIUM (IF APPLICABLE)

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IDEA INFORMATION

IDEA TITLE (18 / 20 words)

The Science of Arguing Better: A Research Center Investigating How Constructive Disagreement Cultivates Character Virtues and Advances Truth-Seeking

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE IDEA (700 / 700 words)

The moonshot: 80% of American colleges and universities adopt learning through constructive disagreement as part of their core student experience within the next decade. Just as "learning by doing" transformed vocational education and "active learning" reshaped STEM pedagogy, we believe learning through disagreement—structured practice in reasoning across genuine differences—should become a foundational element of higher education. We propose that TWCF invest in a research center dedicated to understanding how this practice cultivates character virtues, and what it reveals about human nature and our capacity for pursuing truth.

The need is urgent—and fundamentally about character. Students report being afraid to voice controversial views. Faculty self-censor. Communities fracture into ideological silos where opposing perspectives are caricatured rather than engaged. This reflects a deficit in intellectual virtues—humility, cognitive empathy, charitable interpretation—that make genuine dialogue possible. Yet the response has been surprisingly thin. Civil discourse initiatives focus on reducing conflict. But disagreement is the greatest engine of intellectual progress. The problem is not that people disagree; it is that we have lost our ability to disagree wisely.

This represents an opportunity for contrarian thinking—precisely the kind TWCF is positioned to support. While others fund conflict reduction, we propose investing in conflict optimization: research and tools that harness the generative power of disagreement.

Sway (www.swaybeta.ai), an AI-scaffolded dialogue platform developed by philosophers Simon Cullen and Nicholas DiBella, offers proof of concept. Deployed at over 80 colleges and universities across nine countries with more than 8,500 students, supported by a $4 million Department of Education grant expanding to 125 campuses, and featured in The Chronicle of Higher Education, Sway pairs students who genuinely disagree for structured conversations with real-time AI facilitation. Across 7,900 post-chat surveys, 93% report their partner was respectful despite fundamental disagreement, 91% felt comfortable sharing sincere views, and 59% found their partner had better reasons than expected—directly evidencing intellectual humility developing through practice. 42% changed their minds. As Kenneth Stern told the U.S. Senate: "It's like John Stuart Mill on AI." Sway also won a $341,647 AVDF grant and the global Learning Engineering Tools Competition (selected from over 1,000 entries).

A research center anchored by Sway would investigate fundamental questions across six interconnected domains:

1. The Nature of Constructive Disagreement. What cognitive and social mechanisms distinguish productive intellectual conflict from destructive tribalism? Sway's dataset enables systematic investigation of when and why disagreements go well or badly.

2. Character Virtue Development Through Practice. Do intellectual virtues—humility, curiosity, open-mindedness—develop through guided practice of disagreement? Longitudinal studies could track whether repeated practice produces lasting dispositional change, and identify what individual and contextual factors shape this growth.

3. Facilitative AI as Scaffold for Human Wisdom. How can AI facilitate rather than replace distinctly human capacities? Sway represents a fundamentally different vision of human-AI collaboration: using machine intelligence to scaffold human virtue rather than substitute for it.

4. Cross-Cultural Dimensions. Are the mechanisms by which disagreement cultivates virtue universal or culturally specific? Studies across diverse institutions and countries would extend reach while generating scientifically valuable cross-cultural data.

5. Research-in-the-Loop Methodology. By embedding validated instruments directly into Sway's architecture, measurement and refinement occur continuously—transforming the platform from research subject into research infrastructure.

6. Dialogue on Ultimate Questions. Extending virtue development into domains of religious and spiritual significance—interfaith dialogue about God, suffering, transcendence, and science/religion—directly applying constructive disagreement research to the Big Questions at TWCF's heart.

This proposal is uniquely timely. Sway has demonstrated that AI-scaffolded disagreement works at scale, ready to grow from dozens of institutions to thousands. Large language models now enable scaffolding of human reasoning and dialogue in ways impossible five years ago. And "disagreement science" does not yet exist as a discipline—TWCF has precedent for building fields.

Sir John Templeton made his fortune as a contrarian investor, going long where others saw only risk. This proposal asks TWCF to make a contrarian intellectual bet: that the solution to destructive disagreement is not less conflict but better conflict; that AI can enhance human wisdom rather than replace it; and that rigorous inquiry can illuminate questions long considered the province of philosophy alone. If this wager pays off, the implications extend far beyond higher education.

TWCF FUNDING AREA

Character Virtue Development

DISCIPLINE(S)

Philosophy (5003), Psychology (5201), Artificial Intelligence (4602), Education (3901)

FUNDING AREA JUSTIFICATION (100 / 100 words)

Sway plausibly cultivates character virtues—intellectual humility, curiosity, open-mindedness, and charitable interpretation—through guided practice of constructive disagreement. Unlike programs that teach about virtues, Sway creates conditions requiring their actual exercise, testing the Aristotelian insight that virtues develop through habituation—never empirically tested at scale. Evidence already suggests this works: 59% of students found their partner had better reasons than expected, directly measuring intellectual humility developing through practice. The proposed center would investigate how these learnable attributes develop, what accelerates growth, and how AI can scaffold genuine character formation—from political and moral disagreements to questions of faith and meaning.

KEYWORDS

disagreement science, intellectual humility, truth-seeking, AI-scaffolded dialogue, human flourishing

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SUPPORTING DOCUMENTS

See TWCF_Supporting_Materials.pdf

Supporting Materials

Templeton World Charity Foundation — Request for Ideas

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Expanded proposal detailing the research center's six domains, from character virtue development to dialogue on questions of faith and meaning

2 **Religion & Big Questions on Sway** 11
Topic library, religiously affiliated institutions, and religion-related courses across traditions

3 **Student Dialogues** 13
Two complete anonymized Sway conversations on religion topics, each with survey data, full chat transcript, and Understanding Quiz

a. **Science and Religion (NOMA)** 14
One student changes position after arguments about overlapping truth-claims, the Scopes trial, and competing explanations of reality

b. **Augustine's Conversion** 20
A believer and non-believer engage questions of virtue, spiritual surrender, and whether moral transformation requires God

4 **Platform-Wide Student Survey Data** 26
Post-conversation survey distributions across 7,900 responses at 80+ institutions, measuring respect, intellectual humility, and AI facilitation quality

5 **Sample Instructor Report** 28
Students Debate Evolution and Faith — thematic analysis, opinion data, and AI-guided conversation summaries across 14 peer dialogues

6 **Student Feedback Showcase** 36
Student responses demonstrating perspective-taking and engagement across contentious topics

7 **Sway News & Recognition** 39
Awards, grants, Senate testimony, and media coverage from NBC News, Chronicle, Inside Higher Ed, EdScoop, and more

8 **Chronicle of Higher Education Feature** 41
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9 **Sway Across the Curriculum** 47
Deployment breadth spanning philosophy, political science, psychology, business, nursing, engineering, and more at 80+ institutions

Extended Research Proposal

THE SCIENCE OF ARGUING BETTER

A Research Center for Constructive Disagreement

Our Vision

The moonshot: *80% of American colleges and universities adopt learning through constructive disagreement as part of their core student experience within the next decade.*

Just as "learning by doing" transformed vocational education and "active learning" reshaped STEM pedagogy, we believe learning through disagreement—structured practice in reasoning across genuine differences—should become a foundational element of higher education. Students should graduate not merely having learned *about* intellectual virtues like humility and open-mindedness, but having actually *practiced* them in challenging conversations with people who see the world differently.

To achieve this, we propose to establish a basic science research center dedicated to understanding how human beings can learn to disagree constructively—and through disagreeing better, think better, live better, and flourish together. Anchored by **Sway**, an AI-scaffolded dialogue platform already deployed at more than 80 colleges and universities in nine countries, with more than 8,500 college and university students, this center would provide the scientific foundation, technological infrastructure, and training protocols necessary to scale learning through disagreement from early adopters to mainstream practice.

It would investigate fundamental questions at the intersection of philosophy, psychology, and computer science: What cognitive and social mechanisms distinguish productive intellectual conflict from destructive tribalism? How do virtues like intellectual humility and cognitive empathy develop through practice? How can artificial intelligence effectively scaffold rather than degrade human reasoning and discourse? And what can these dynamics reveal about human nature and our collective capacity for pursuing truth?

This research agenda directly advances TWCF's mission of promoting discovery that inspires new perspectives on life's deepest questions. Sir John Templeton believed

humanity's rate of spiritual development was "only now beginning to accelerate," and that scientific methods could catalyze this acceleration. A center studying constructive disagreement embodies this vision: it applies rigorous inquiry to a fundamental question about human flourishing while developing practical tools that enable more people to engage the Big Questions with humility, curiosity, and intellectual courage.

When Disagreement Becomes Destructive

The ability to reason together across genuine differences may be the most important cognitive capacity humans possess—and the most imperiled. Polarization research documents a troubling trajectory: not merely that people disagree more intensely, but that they have lost faith in the very possibility of productive exchange. Students report being afraid to voice their views. Faculty self-censor. Communities fracture into ideological silos where opposing perspectives are caricatured rather than engaged. The marketplace of ideas that John Stuart Mill championed as essential for both individual development and collective truth-seeking shows signs of market collapse.

This is not merely a political problem but a characterological one, reflecting a deficit in the intellectual virtues—humility, cognitive empathy, charitable interpretation, epistemically responsible reasoning—that make genuine dialogue possible.

Yet the response to this crisis has been surprisingly thin. Civil discourse initiatives typically focus on reducing conflict. This approach misses something profound. The problem is not that people disagree; to the contrary, disagreement is the greatest engine of intellectual progress. The problem is that we have lost our ability to disagree wisely. We lack both the skills for productive intellectual conflict and the institutional infrastructure that make such conflict safe enough to attempt.

This represents an opportunity for contrarian thinking—precisely the kind TWCF is positioned to support. While others fund conflict reduction, we propose investing in conflict optimization: research and tools that help people harness the generative power of disagreement rather than merely suppressing it.

The Opportunity: the Science of Arguing Better

Sway offers proof of concept that a different approach is possible. Developed with

Heterodox Academy by philosophers **Simon Cullen** (UNC Chapel Hill, Heterodox Academy) and **Nicholas DiBella** (Heterodox Academy), Sway pairs students who disagree on contested topics—abortion, the existence of God, Israel-Palestine, whether science and religion conflict, transgender athletes, immigration—for structured, AI-scaffolded conversations. Unlike civility training that teaches *about* constructive disagreement, Sway creates conditions where students must actually *practice* it, with real-time AI facilitation and automatic charitable rephrasing to teach habits of rigorous and respectful disagreement. For a brief demonstration, see **youtube.com/watch?v=KJ4qlIZoZfM**.

The results have been striking. Across more than 7,900 post-conversation surveys:

- 93% of participants report that their partner treated them respectfully—despite nearly all pairs beginning with fundamental disagreement
- 91% felt comfortable sharing their sincere views; 90% were not offended by their partner's perspective
- 59% found their partner had better reasons than expected—a direct measure of intellectual humility developing through practice
- 42% changed their minds about something

As Kenneth Stern, Director of Bard College's Center for the Study of Hate, **told the U.S. Senate**: "It's like John Stuart Mill on AI."

This traction has attracted significant recognition: a **$4 million Department of Education FIPSE grant** (as part of a consortium studying nearly 100,000 students—with 48,000 trained directly on Sway—across 125 campuses), selection as one of six winners from over 1,000 entries in the global **Learning Engineering Tools Competition**, a **$341,647 grant from the Arthur Vining Davis Foundations**, and adoption at institutions ranging from Harvard and UCLA to BYU, the University of Toronto, and the University of Cape Town—from community colleges to research universities across nine countries. Sway has been featured in **Inside Higher Ed**, **NBC News**, and **The Chronicle of Higher Education**.

But Sway's greatest potential lies not in what it has already accomplished—it is what it could become: the research infrastructure for a new science of scalable constructive disagreement, and the engine that makes 80% adoption achievable.

A Research Agenda for Human Flourishing

We envision a research center that investigates fundamental questions across six

interconnected domains, with character virtue development as the central organizing theme:

The Nature of Constructive Disagreement

What distinguishes productive intellectual conflict from destructive tribalism? Current theory suggests factors like intellectual humility, perspective-taking, and epistemic trust, but empirical tests remain limited by methodological constraints. Sway generates structured data on thousands of real disagreements, enabling systematic empirical investigation of when and why disagreements go well or badly. We expect this basic research to yield transformative insights into human cognition, social psychology, and the conditions that promote rational discourse.

Character Virtue Development Through Practice

How do intellectual virtues like humility, curiosity, and open-mindedness actually develop? Traditional virtue ethics emphasizes that virtues are cultivated through practice rather than instruction—yet this Aristotelian insight has never been empirically tested at scale. Sway provides an unprecedented opportunity to do so.

Our survey data already suggests the habituation thesis holds: 59% of students report that their partner had better reasons than they expected, and 82% felt their partner was genuinely trying to understand their perspective—indicating that a single structured conversation can shift someone's assessment of how reasonable their opponents are. This is intellectual humility developing through practice, not instruction. Sway's Understanding Quiz goes further: after each conversation, students answer questions testing their comprehension of their partner's specific arguments and reasoning—not whether they agree, but whether they can accurately represent what the other person argued and why. This operationalizes perspective-taking as a measurable behavioral outcome rather than a self-reported attitude.

A research center would investigate the full dose-response relationship: Does repeated practice build lasting dispositions toward intellectual virtue? What is the trajectory of change across multiple conversations? Can AI scaffolding accelerate virtue development, and if so, which strategies are most effective? What individual differences—cognitive style, prior exposure to diversity, moral foundations—predict capacity for growth? These questions are at the heart of TWCF's Character Virtue Development mission and represent the central organizing theme of the proposed research center.

'Facilitative AI' as Scaffold for Human Wisdom

What role can artificial intelligence play in facilitating rather than replacing distinctly human capacities? Most AI research focuses on automation and efficiency; by contrast, we

investigate facilitation and cultivation. Sway's AI discussion facilitator, Guide, doesn't tell students what to think—it helps them articulate and defend their own views while also recognizing their weaknesses and genuinely understanding opposing perspectives. This represents a fundamentally different vision of human-AI collaboration, one that uses machine intelligence to scaffold and empower human wisdom rather than substitute for it.

Cross-Cultural and Global Dimensions

How do disagreement dynamics vary across cultures and contexts? TWCF prioritizes geographic diversity and "majority world" perspectives. A research center could investigate whether the conditions for constructive disagreement are universal or culturally specific, and how interventions might be adapted for different contexts. Sway is already in use at colleges and universities across nine countries, with growing international demand. This global orientation would extend Sway's reach while generating scientifically valuable cross-cultural data.

Research-in-the-Loop Methodology

Traditional social science operates on timescales poorly suited to rapidly evolving technological interventions: multi-year grants fund studies whose findings, by publication, may no longer reflect current platform capabilities. We propose a fundamentally different model—research-in-the-loop—in which measurement, analysis, and refinement occur continuously within the operational platform. By embedding validated assessment instruments directly into Sway's architecture—drawing on co-investigator Louis Tay's expertise in psychometric measurement of character strengths, and including established scales for intellectual humility and open-mindedness, NLP-based measures of argument quality and perspective-taking, and pre/post attitude surveys administered at scale—we can track virtue development across hundreds of thousands of conversations, identify which AI scaffolding strategies produce which outcomes for which users, and implement evidence-based refinements within weeks rather than years. This transforms Sway from a research subject into research infrastructure—a living laboratory for the science of constructive disagreement. The outputs: continuously updated effect-size estimates, evidence-based facilitation guidelines, validated instruments for measuring constructive disagreement, and open datasets for the broader research community.

Dialogue on Ultimate Questions

TWCF's mission centers on humanity's spiritual search for meaning, purpose, and truth—and this represents the hardest test case for character virtue development through practice: can intellectual humility be cultivated through dialogue about the existence of God, the relationship between science and faith, or the problem of suffering? Remarkably, Sway students are already engaging with these questions. Twelve active chat topics

address science and religion directly—including whether science and religion address nonoverlapping domains (Gould's NOMA), whether evolutionary accounts undermine moral status, whether accepting evolution affects one's relationship with God, and whether scripture or science should take priority when they appear to conflict. These conversations are already taking place at religiously affiliated institutions including Brigham Young University (where students in Principles of Biology engage evolution alongside their faith) and the University of St. Thomas (Dialogue and Disagreement in Religiously Diverse Societies). Interest spans faith traditions, with instructors from Abilene Christian University to Cambridge Muslim College signing up to use Sway for courses in Christian ethics, theology, and interfaith dialogue. The de-identified student conversations included in the accompanying materials illustrate these dynamics in action. A research center would deepen this already-existing engagement—co-designing more sophisticated modules with theologians, philosophers of religion, and leaders from diverse faith traditions while systematically studying the conditions under which AI scaffolding cultivates the intellectual virtues that make religious and spiritual discourse fruitful. This is the most direct application of constructive disagreement research to the Big Questions at the heart of TWCF's mission.

Strategic Alignment with TWCF's Mission

This proposal aligns with multiple TWCF priorities while embodying the foundation's distinctive approach to philanthropy:

Character Virtue Development. This is the central focus of the proposed center. Sway cultivates intellectual humility, cognitive empathy, curiosity, and open-mindedness through structured practice—precisely the "learned and learnable attributes intrinsically connected to human flourishing" that TWCF seeks to advance. Unlike programs that teach *about* virtues, Sway creates conditions requiring their actual *exercise*. When 59% of students discover their partner had better reasons than expected, we are observing the Aristotelian habituation thesis in data form: virtue developing through repeated practice, one conversation at a time.

Big Questions. How can communities of inquirers with different priors and values make collective epistemic progress? What are the conditions for rational discourse under genuine uncertainty? Students on the platform are already exploring these questions in their most profound form—debating whether science and religion address separate domains, whether God exists, and what evolution means for human moral status. These questions about the nature and possibility of truth-seeking through dialogue connect

directly to TWCF's interest in fundamental epistemology and the human search for meaning.

Listening and Learning in a Polarized World. The research center would directly advance TWCF's existing priority by providing scalable scientific infrastructure for studying polarization and depolarization mechanisms. Sway enables studies impossible with surveys or in-person methods: replicable, large-scale, real-time observation of actual disagreements with experimental manipulation of AI facilitation strategies.

Individual Freedom. By making it safer to engage across difference—through pseudonymous conversations, AI mediation, and protected spaces for exploring "dangerous ideas"—Sway provides infrastructure for the marketplace of ideas that Mill argued was essential for human progress. This connects to TWCF's explicit interest in freedom of conscience and defending threats to existing freedoms.

The Humble Approach. Sir John Templeton's conviction that "we have not grasped 1% of what can be known about spiritual realities" implies that engaging opposing perspectives is not merely civically useful but epistemically essential. You cannot pursue truth with humility while refusing to engage those who see things differently. Sway operationalizes this insight.

Why Now

Three factors make this a uniquely catalytic moment for investing in the science of constructive disagreement:

Proof of concept exists. Sway has demonstrated that AI-scaffolded constructive disagreement works at scale. With over 8,500 students at more than 80 colleges and universities in nine countries, recognition from Congress to the Department of Education, and robust outcome data, we have moved beyond theory to demonstrated feasibility. Early adopters span research universities, liberal arts colleges, community colleges, religiously affiliated universities—including BYU, where students debate evolution alongside their faith—and high schools. The demand to scale is already evident: instructors at institutions from Columbia and MIT to Howard University and Georgetown Law have signed up to use the platform. The infrastructure is ready to scale—from 80+ to hundreds, from hundreds to the thousands needed to reach 80% of American higher education, and beyond universities into community organizations and workplaces. The question is no longer whether this approach can work, but how far it can go.

AI creates new research possibilities. Large language models enable scaffolding of human dialogue in ways that were impossible five years ago. This technological capability arrives at precisely the moment when society most needs tools for bridging divides. A research center can investigate the frontier of human-AI collaboration in discourse while the field is nascent enough to shape its trajectory.

The field lacks institutional infrastructure. "Disagreement science" does not yet exist as a recognized discipline. There is no dedicated research center, no flagship journal, no field-building infrastructure. TWCF has precedent for building fields—its $30 million investment in Accelerating Research on Consciousness, its human flourishing initiatives, its support for research hubs across multiple universities. A similar commitment here could catalyze an entirely new domain of inquiry. **Heterodox Academy**—a leading organization for open inquiry in higher education with over 8,000 faculty members, which has supported Sway since its inception—has expressed interest in housing such a center.

The research team extends beyond the platform's creators. **Louis Tay***, the William C. Byham Professor of Psychology at Purdue University, whose research on psychometric measurement of character strengths is supported by the John Templeton Foundation, is committed as a co-investigator—bringing the validated measurement expertise essential for tracking virtue development longitudinally. His lab's work on well-being and character assessment would provide the methodological foundation for the center's core empirical program.*

A Contrarian Wager

Sir John Templeton made his fortune as a contrarian investor, going long where others saw only risk. This proposal asks TWCF to make a contrarian intellectual bet: that the solution to destructive disagreement is not less conflict but *better* conflict; that AI can enhance human wisdom rather than replace it; that virtues are built through guided practice, not instruction; and that rigorous scientific inquiry can illuminate questions long considered the province of philosophy alone.

If this wager pays off, the implications extend far beyond higher education. The basic science of constructive disagreement could inform how families navigate differences, how organizations make decisions, how democracies function, and how humanity collectively pursues the Big Questions that give life its shape and meaning. It could demonstrate that in an age of artificial intelligence, the most important human capacities—reasoning together, pursuing truth, growing in wisdom—can be cultivated rather than abandoned.

We invite TWCF to partner in building the institutional infrastructure for humanity to argue better—and through arguing better, to flourish together. The moonshot is ambitious: transform how an entire generation learns to engage across difference. But the foundation is already laid, the proof of concept demonstrated, and the moment uniquely ripe.

Religion & Big Questions on Sway

How constructive disagreement naturally extends to questions of faith, science, and meaning — www.swaybeta.ai

Sway is a constructive disagreement platform, not a religion platform. But questions about God, faith, suffering, and meaning are among the most deeply held—and the most difficult to discuss across genuine differences. This makes them a natural fit for AI-scaffolded dialogue, and instructors have independently recognized this. Across both secular and religiously affiliated institutions, educators have created dialogue topics and integrated Sway into courses that engage with religion, science, ethics, and human meaning.

Religiously Affiliated Institutions — Active Usage

Students at the following religiously affiliated institutions have used Sway in courses. The range of traditions is notable—LDS, Catholic, Disciples of Christ, and United Methodist—each adopting the platform independently.

INSTITUTION	AFFILIATION	COURSES
Brigham Young University	LDS	Principles of Biology, Psychology of Gender, Grad Teaching Seminar, Child Psychopathology
BYU-Idaho	LDS	Peace & Conflict
University of St. Thomas	Catholic	Dialogue and Disagreement in Religiously Diverse Societies
Providence College	Catholic (Dominican)	General Ethics
Duquesne University	Catholic (Spiritan)	Communication Research Methods, Essential Questions
Texas Christian University	Disciples of Christ	Introduction to Political Theory, Business Information Systems
Simpson College	United Methodist	Foundations I

Demand from religiously affiliated institutions is growing. Instructors at Abilene Christian University (Churches of Christ), Baylor University (Baptist), Georgetown Law and Gonzaga University (Jesuit), Holy Apostles College & Seminary and Dominican University (Catholic), Cambridge Muslim College (Islamic), George Fox University (Quaker), and Soka University of America (Buddhist) have all signed up to use Sway—extending the platform's reach across Christian, Islamic, and Buddhist traditions.

Religion-Related Courses

Religion and big questions surface not only at religiously affiliated schools but across secular institutions. At the University of St. Thomas, students used Sway in *Dialogue and Disagreement in Religiously Diverse Societies*. At Brigham Young University, instructors integrated Sway into *Principles of Biology*—where evolution and faith directly intersect—and *Psychology of Gender*. At secular institutions, students have debated God's existence (UNC Chapel Hill), the value of religion to society (Grand Valley State University), and the relationship between science and faith (Hobart & William Smith Colleges, Douglas College).

Interest continues to grow. Instructors have signed up to use Sway in courses including *Introduction to Christian Ethics* (Abilene Christian University), *Israel-Palestine in the Religious Imagination* (Franklin & Marshall College), and *World Religions* and *Philosophy of Religion* (John A. Logan College).

Dialogue Topics

Students on Sway have discussed the following topics across multiple institutions and courses. Each is framed as a position students can agree or disagree with, enabling Sway to match peers who hold opposing views.

The Existence of God
God exists.
UNC Chapel Hill

Reason to Believe
There is no reason to believe in God.
Douglas College — Critical Thinking

The Benefit of Religion
Do you believe religion is beneficial to society?
Grand Valley State University — Borders, Bodies, and Rights

Religion and Moral Values
Religion plays a critical role in shaping an individual's moral values.
Mount Mercy University — Human Relations

Purpose of Interfaith Work
Interfaith initiatives should focus primarily on promoting social justice and political change rather than on fostering personal relationships or theological understanding.
University of St. Thomas — Dialogue and Disagreement in Religiously Diverse Societies

Climate Change and Faith
My faith or religious beliefs influence how I think about climate change.
Brigham Young University — Principles of Biology

NOMA (Nonoverlapping Magisteria)
Science and religion address nonoverlapping domains and therefore need not conflict.
Hobart & William Smith Colleges — Evolution

Design vs. Descent
Evolution by natural selection fully explains apparent design in living things.
Hobart & William Smith Colleges — Evolution

Evolution and Relationship with God
Accepting human evolution would have impact on my relationship with God.
Brigham Young University — Principles of Biology

Evolution and Human Exceptionalism
If humans evolved, that would mean humans are simply animals.
Brigham Young University — Principles of Biology

Scientists vs. Christians
Scientists are generally antagonistic toward Christians.
Brigham Young University — Principles of Biology

Is Over Over?
Death is not the end of us.
Douglas College — Critical Thinking

Two complete anonymized Sway dialogue transcripts on religion topics follow, with survey data, full chat transcripts, and Understanding Quizzes. The first concerns whether science and religion address nonoverlapping domains (NOMA); the second concerns whether Augustine's conversion is admirable.

Student Dialogues

Two conversations on questions of faith, science, and meaning — www.swaybeta.ai

What follows are two complete Sway conversations, exported directly from the platform. Student names have been replaced with pseudonyms. Each transcript contains three components:

Survey Results — Pre- and post-conversation opinion ratings on a 7-point scale, showing how each student's position changed, along with partner ratings on respect, understanding, and AI facilitator fairness.

Chat Transcript — The full conversation between two students and Sway's AI discussion facilitator, Guide. Guide does not take sides; it challenges both students' reasoning, surfaces tensions, and pushes toward depth.

Understanding Quiz — After the conversation, each student answers questions about their *partner's* specific arguments and reasoning—not topic knowledge, but whether they can accurately represent what the other person argued and why. This is perspective-taking measured as a behavioral outcome.

Dialogue 1: Science and Religion (NOMA)

Nonoverlapping Magisteria — from an undergraduate Evolution course

Taylor and Alexandra debate whether science and religion address nonoverlapping domains. Taylor argues they govern separate aspects of understanding: science handles evidence, religion handles meaning and the soul. Alexandra counters that their boundaries blur: questions about origins are *"both scientific and moral,"* and using God as a placeholder is *"only useful until those gaps are filled in by science."* Through arguments about the soul's untestability, the Scopes trial, and competing claims about reality, Taylor is persuaded: *"I think you have convinced me that I now disagree that they cannot be separate."* Guide also catches a tension in Alexandra's reasoning, pressing her to reconcile calling the domains "separate" with her earlier argument that they are "competing interpretations of the same world."

Opinion change: Taylor shifts 3 points toward rejecting NOMA. Alexandra shifts 2 points toward accepting it.

Dialogue 2: Augustine's Conversion

Virtue, spiritual surrender, and moral transformation — from an undergraduate General Ethics course

Emma and Owen debate whether Augustine's conversion is admirable. Owen opens with a nuanced position: the process described in the *Confessions* is *"beautiful,"* but the conversion itself cannot undo past sins— *"simply converting to Christianity doesn't take away"* what he did. Emma reframes conversion as a lifelong endeavor demonstrating humility and courage. The conversation evolves into a philosophical exchange: Owen invokes Aristotelian virtue ethics, arguing virtue develops through habitual practice, not a single act; Emma gradually separates the religious dimension from the moral one, arguing Augustine's character change is universally admirable regardless of belief. Guide presses both—asking Emma what makes the conversion *specifically* admirable beyond self-improvement, and asking Owen whether spiritual surrender requires a different kind of humility.

Opinion change: Owen shifts 3 points toward finding the conversion admirable—the maximum possible movement on the scale.

Both students in each conversation answered the Understanding Quiz correctly on nearly every question—demonstrating that they could accurately reconstruct their partner's reasoning even where they continued to disagree.

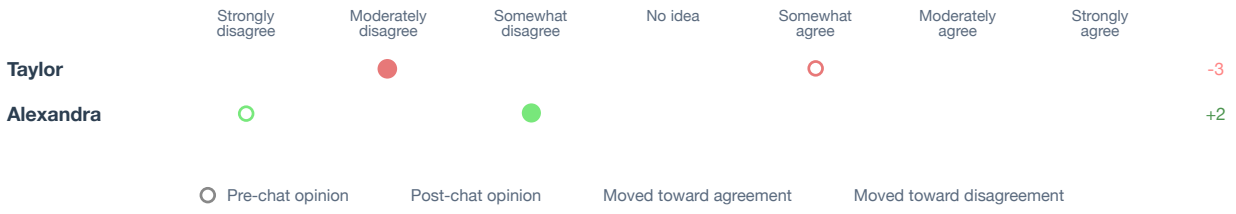
Students Discuss NOMA (nonoverlapping Magisteria)

Privacy Notice: Student names have been replaced with pseudonyms to protect privacy.

Survey results

Opinion Changes

Students rated the following statement: *Science and religion address nonoverlapping domains—facts vs. values—and therefore need not conflict.*



Partner Ratings

Statement	Strongly Disagree	Disagree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly Agree
Guide's contributions improved the discussion	—	—	—	Taylor	Alexandra
Guide treated me and my partner with equal respect	—	—	—	Taylor	—
Guide supported both sides of the discussion equally	—	—	Alexandra	Taylor	—
I felt comfortable sharing my honest opinions with my partner	—	—	—	Taylor	—
I was not offended by my partner's perspective	—	—	—	—	Taylor Alexandra
My partner was respectful	—	—	—	—	Alexandra
My partner was genuinely trying to understand my perspective	—	—	—	—	Alexandra
My partner had better reasons for their views than I expected	—	—	—	Alexandra	—
Sway helped me articulate my thoughts/feelings better	—	—	—	Taylor	—

Optional open feedback

"How did this Sway chat affect your confidence discussing complex issues with people who hold different views from you?"

Alexandra: "The guide was helpful! I think it was critical in steering the conversation towards meaningful discourse instead of allowing us to get wrapped up in the same debate and points over and over again."

💬 Word Counts

AI GUIDE	STUDENT	STUDENT
453 words	**Alexandra**	**Taylor**
7 messages	698 words · 9 messages	666 words · 10 messages

Chat transcript

Guide October 17, 2025, 12:35 AM

👋 Welcome, everyone!

Our topic is NOMA (Nonoverlapping Magisteria). We'll be discussing this statement:

Science and religion address nonoverlapping domains—facts vs. values—and therefore need not conflict.

- Taylor agrees with the statement.
- Alexandra disagrees with the statement.

My name is Guide, and I'm here to support your discussion. If you need anything, start your message with "Hey Guide" 🤓

Taylor October 17, 2025, 12:35 AM

hey guide

Guide October 17, 2025, 12:35 AM

Hey Taylor! 👋

I'm here to help facilitate your discussion with Alexandra. Since you two are just getting started, why don't you begin by coordinating with each other about how you'd like to chat? You can go back-and-forth in real-time or take turns responding when it works for your schedules.

Once you're ready, jump into the topic! You might start by sharing **why** you think science and religion occupy separate domains, and Alexandra can explain her disagreement.

What questions do you have?

Taylor October 17, 2025, 12:38 AM

I think that what we touched on at the end of class where if people aren't infringing on other people's rights than it is okay for people to base their values, like where the soul comes from on their religious beliefs, and they can still separate it from the idea that evolution created the physical body of an organism

Alexandra October 17, 2025, 2:43 AM

I think that is a compelling argument, and I can see how people can hold religious beliefs about the soul while also accepting scientific explanations like evolution. To be honest, I don't really understand what a soul is. However, I disagree that science and religion ALWAYS occupy completely separate spheres. In practice, their boundaries blur, and saying ALWAYS separate is risky, as these issues are not static and rather, held in a flux. For example, I think questions about the origins of life (biblical explanations vs the big bang) are both scientific and moral in nature, and they really do influence each other. To put it simply, I don't think two things can EVER exist independent of one another, or completely separated from one another.

Taylor October 17, 2025, 3:22 AM

I agree that there are boundaries of the origin of life where things get blurry and some people take a scientific approach while others take a biblical approach. I think that there is that interaction of both ideas, they ultimately govern different aspects of life in understanding the world. I think science seeks out evidence, observations, and testable ideas and religion may be able to answer the gaps of why we exist and a spiritual meaning. Religion offers relief for the unknown and provide answers for what comes after death. Evolution cannot act on dead organisms, so it would be up to religion or spirituality at that point what happens to the individual.

> **Guide** October 17, 2025, 3:22 AM
>
> **Taylor, how do you respond to Alexandra's point that these domains can't be *completely* separate?**
>
> You seem to acknowledge that boundaries get "blurry" around life's origins, but then you still maintain they "ultimately govern different aspects of life."
>
> If they blur at the boundaries—especially on fundamental questions like origins—doesn't that suggest they *do* overlap rather than occupy truly separate magisteria?

Taylor October 17, 2025, 3:24 AM

I guess they can't truly be completely separate, but I also don't think that they fully overlap but that there is room for aspects of both ideas to coexist

Alexandra October 17, 2025, 6:19 PM

I agree that there is room for both to exist, however, I think that using God as a placeholder or explanation for the gaps is only useful until those gaps are filled in by developments in science, which then leads to overlap and further tension between religious and scientific explanations.

Taylor October 17, 2025, 8:25 PM

That makes a lot of sense. I think that something the professor touched on was that there isn't much empirical data that can prove or disprove the presence of a soul in an individual. This would also leave open questions about is a soul exclusive to humans (which would support the presence of a human focused god for many religious people) or do other beings have a soul as well. I agree that this would cause overlap, but I also have trouble thinking of a way to test whether a soul is present or not. I think gaps like these are often filled with spirituality. Something you mentioned in class also that more research will just bring up more questions, which I think a large amount of people will always find a way to fill with religion or spirituality

> **Guide** October 17, 2025, 8:25 PM
>
> **Alexandra, Taylor seems to be conceding significant ground here—acknowledging overlap while suggesting some gaps (like the soul) might be permanently untestable.**
>
> Does this move satisfy your objection? Or do you think even "untestable" religious claims about souls create tensions with science in ways that violate NOMA?

Alexandra October 20, 2025, 12:20 AM

I totally agree. The soul can exist in its own domain (somewhat), but I like to imagine this more as a Venn Diagram rather than two separate spheres. There are always going to be things that overlap, and I think that is just part of existence, thought, conscience.

Taylor October 20, 2025, 1:23 AM

I'd agree that for many people, there's an overlap in how they think about these topics. I do still think that at

the core of religion and evolution they belong in different categories of understanding. I think the approach and purpose they serve are separate even if the way people think about it may overlap.

Alexandra October 20, 2025, 5:03 PM

I agree that science and religion often have different goals (maybe science seeks to explain how things work, while religion often addresses why they matter), but even with these purposes their separation isn't as clean as NOMA suggests. Both science and religion make claims about reality, and those claims often directly contradict each other. Basically, while I agree that there are different categories of understanding, they can't be distinct because they are competing interpretations of the same world.

> **Guide** October 20, 2025, 5:03 PM
>
> **Taylor, can you defend the idea that their "core" purposes remain separate when, as Alexandra points out, both make claims about reality that sometimes contradict?**
>
> For instance, if a religious text claims the Earth is 6,000 years old and science demonstrates it's billions of years old, aren't they competing to answer the *same* question about reality—not different ones?

Taylor October 22, 2025, 1:38 AM

I would agree that the core purpose is separate, and I also agree that the claims they make can contradict. I think you have convinced me that I now disagree that they cannot be separate. I think this reminds me of the article from Huse where he states more than a page of contradictions between the bible and evolutionary biology. I think that article is very convincing and supports your points well.

Alexandra October 22, 2025, 4:53 PM

Both religion and science deserve their own respect, and regardless of my personal opinions on religion, I think there is space for the two to coexist even though they occupy separate domains that really work to explain the same concepts.

> **Guide** October 22, 2025, 4:53 PM
>
> **Alexandra, you just said they "occupy separate domains" but earlier you argued they *can't* be distinct because they're "competing interpretations of the same world."**
>
> Which is it? If they're competing to explain the same concepts (origins, reality, etc.), how can they occupy separate domains?
>
> This seems like a significant tension in your position.

Alexandra October 22, 2025, 4:55 PM

They can occupy separate domains, but when that distinction is dissected, religion and science are really addressing the same issues. Where people argue that they are nonoverlapping, I'd argue that it might be appear to be the case, but after discussion and getting to the root of both explanations, they are both working to explain the SAME things, putting them back into the same categories (like a Venn diagram)

Taylor October 22, 2025, 7:03 PM

I think even when they do contradict when providing explanations for certain geological and evolutionary events, people can still separate the two. As some people during discussion mentioned, they can put each ideas aside depending on the context and the question at hand. Many people shared that in class, like evolution, they are able to put their religious beliefs aside and look empirically at their work while still maintaining their faith.

Alexandra October 22, 2025, 10:58 PM

It would be really cool if everyone could do that. But unfortunately, most people cannot. I'm thinking specifically about the Scopes trial, where a teacher was charged and brought to court for teaching evolution in a school setting during a science course. Evolution was something that couldn't be taught in schools because it conflicted with the origin story that religion (specifically Christianity) was born from. Although I am mentioning here that the belief systems directly contradicted each other and were occupying different spheres of explanation, I think that despite being different ways of explaining, they are explaining the SAME issue. In the case of the Scopes trial, they were both explaining the origin of life. While they may seem to occupy different spheres of thought and magisteria, the conflicts over the same issues show that they cannot exist separate from one another in reality.

Guide October 22, 2025, 10:58 PM

Taylor, Alexandra just gave a concrete historical example where religious and scientific claims directly competed over the *same* question—origins—leading to legal conflict.

You've acknowledged contradictions exist, but you're suggesting people can just "put aside" one or the other depending on context.

Doesn't the Scopes trial show that this compartmentalization breaks down in practice? If people *could* truly separate them, why would there be legal battles over what gets taught?

Taylor October 23, 2025, 4:41 AM

I think this is a very good point and I agree that this trial shows that it may be difficult to keep both of them separate. I think situations like the Scopes trial show a lot about society's struggle to balance the two rather than whether or not they can be separate. I think in this situation it was wrong for the teacher to go to court. Since it was a science class it would be appropriate to teach evolution (empirical evidence, theories, research) while a religion classes can provide biblical teachings (spirituality, morals, purpose) of the same questions. I think it would then be up to the indiviual to decide which magisteria better suits their questions.

Alexandra October 23, 2025, 9:05 PM

I agree with you that ideally, science and religion could and should each stay in their own spaces. Science classrooms should teach empirical evidence and religious spaces should focus on spiritual meaning. If that separation were possible in practice, then NOMA would work much better. But I think the challenge is that in reality, people's beliefs influence institutions, laws, and education systems. Even when something is labeled as 'science', what's allowed to be taught or funded often depends on prevailing religious or cultural views. That's why the Scopes trial wasn't just about one teacher, but rather reflected how deeply intertwined religion and science are in shaping public understanding.

Understanding Quiz

Taylor

When you began the discussion, Alexandra disagreed that science and religion ALWAYS occupy completely separate domains. What reason did she give for this view?

Justification

- She said that religious explanations are permanent placeholders that never change.
- She claimed that questions about origins are both scientific and moral and that domains blur in... ✓
- She argued that evolution cannot explain moral values, so they must be separate.
- She insisted that empirical data could prove the existence of a soul.

When you suggested that gaps like the soul might be permanently untestable, how did Alexandra respond regarding the use of God as an explanation?

Justification

She said God as an explanation will always remain valid even if science advances.

She agreed untestable gaps can fit separate domains without tension.

She said using God as a placeholder is temporary until science fills gaps, creating...

She recommended discarding God altogether in scientific contexts.

Later, Guide pointed out a tension in Alexandra's position about separate domains versus competing interpretations. How did Alexandra reconcile this tension?

Justification

She maintained the domains never overlap under any circumstance.

She retracted her view and fully endorsed NOMA without reservations.

She described their relationship as a Venn diagram: separate domains but explaining the same...

She claimed science is superior and religion should adapt to it.

When Alexandra cited the Scopes trial, what point was she illustrating?

Justification

That legal conflicts prove people can perfectly compartmentalize science and religion.

That historical events are irrelevant to understanding NOMA.

That societal beliefs influence education and laws, showing religion and science are...

That court cases always resolve conflicts between science and religion.

When Guide challenged you with the Scopes trial example, what assumption about NOMA was being questioned?

Justification

That religious teachings should be excluded from public education entirely.

That people can fully compartmentalize science and religion without real-world...

That science is invalid if it contradicts religious texts.

That Venn diagrams are useful for conceptualizing domains.

Alexandra

At the beginning of the discussion, how did Taylor justify that science and religion can occupy separate magisteria?

Justification

By saying science only deals with spiritual questions and religion focuses on empirical...

By claiming religion and science always share the same domain of factual inquiry.

By insisting religious beliefs should permanently fill any gaps left by scientific research.

By saying religion provides moral and spiritual answers while science offers evidence-based...

When Guide asked whether blurry boundaries around lifes origins imply overlapping magisteria, how did Taylor respond?

Justification

She insisted they remain entirely separate even if boundaries blur.

She agreed they cannot be completely separate but insisted they don't fully overlap and both...

She agreed they fully overlap in all aspects and magisteria no longer apply.

She claimed the overlap only occurs in unrelated domains outside origins.

Why did Taylor argue that religious claims about the soul might remain in a separate domain from science?

Justification

Because science has already conclusively discredited the concept of a soul.

Because religious texts are based on historical records that science cannot access.

Because empirical data cannot prove or disprove a soul, making it permanently untestable by...

Because religion and science work on identical methods of testing ideas.

What source did Taylor cite to support the existence of extensive contradictions between religious and scientific accounts?

Justification

She mentioned class anecdotes where students disagreed on the souls origin.

She discussed a philosophical text arguing that science and religion are incompatible.

She cited a court decision from the Scopes trial to show factual conflicts.

She referenced an article by Huse detailing over a page of contradictions between the Bible...

In her final response about the Scopes trial, how did Taylor suggest handling science and religion in education to avoid conflict?

Justification

Prohibit teaching evolution in any educational setting to respect religious beliefs.

Combine religious and scientific curricula in every classroom to present both sides.

Teach evolution in science classes and biblical teachings in religion classes, leaving the...

Allow only religious explanations in public education and scientific ones privately.

Students Discuss Augustine's Conversion

Privacy Notice: Student names have been replaced with pseudonyms to protect privacy.

Survey results

Opinion Changes

Students rated the following statement: *Augustine's conversion is admirable.*

Partner Ratings

Statement	Strongly Disagree	Disagree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly Agree
I felt comfortable sharing my honest opinions with my partner	—	—	—	Emma	—
My partner was respectful	—	—	—	—	Owen
My partner had better reasons for their views than I expected	—	—	—	Emma	Owen
This discussion improved my perception of my partner	—	—	—	—	Emma Owen
It would be good if more students and classes used Sway	—	—	—	Emma Owen	—
This discussion led me to change my mind about something related to the topic	Emma	—	—	—	Owen

Word Counts

AI GUIDE
347 words
5 messages

STUDENT
Emma
781 words · 6 messages

STUDENT
Owen
741 words · 6 messages

Chat transcript

Guide April 1, 2025, 2:28 PM

👋 Welcome, everyone!

Our topic is Augustine's Conversion. We'll be discussing this statement:

Augustine's conversion is admirable.

- Emma agrees with the statement.
- Owen disagrees with the statement.

My name is Guide, and I'm here to support your discussion. If you need anything, start your message with “Hey Guide” 🤓

Owen April 3, 2025, 6:19 PM

Hey Guide

Guide April 3, 2025, 6:19 PM

Hi Owen! I'm here to help facilitate your discussion with Emma about Augustine's conversion. What can I help you with? Feel free to ask any questions or share your thoughts on the topic, and I'll do my best to guide the conversation.

Owen April 5, 2025, 4:24 PM

I think Augustine's conversion isn't admirable, although the process of conversion as described in his Confessions is beautiful, because his past sins cannot simply be undone by his sudden conversion. He abandoned his son and mistress, and his past actions go against his later teachings of celibacy and chastity. Not to mention the countless other things he confesses to, and his black and white view of the world. Simply converting to Christianity doesn't take away his past sins, and even if what he does after converting is admirable (I do think it is admirable), the conversion itself has no reason to be admirable.

Emma April 5, 2025, 5:43 PM

I understand your view on this, and I can see how people might see Augustine's conversion as a "cover-up" for his past sins. However, I think that because he was willing to admit his mistakes and turn his life around for good, his conversion is admirable. I view a conversion as more than the single moment a person "becomes" a Christian. I think that if someone has the initial realization of sins and that something in their life needs to change, it shows humility and courage, which are admirable qualities. Confession of sins takes strength, so I do not see this as a weakness in Augustine's journey. While you are correct that his past sins were not erased and that they still caused damage, having the humility to admit he did wrong is something to applaud. Also, I see a conversion to Christianity as a lifelong endeavor, and Augustine did this well. For this reason, I believe his conversion is admirable.

Owen April 5, 2025, 7:21 PM

What you said makes a lot of sense, and I hadn't considered that conversion to Christianity could be a lifelong endeavor. I definitely agree that his confession of sins shows humility and courage and is not a sign of weakness. However, if conversion to Christianity is a lifelong journey, this clears up the problem with erasing past sins but not the problem of why his conversion should be admirable. Why should his lifelong journey be any more admirable than anyone else's? Yes, his act of confessing to his sins is admirable, but he could do this without converting too. What is it specifically about the conversion that should be admirable?

Guide April 5, 2025, 7:21 PM

Emma, Owen raises an important question about what makes Augustine's conversion specifically admirable beyond the general virtues of confession and self-improvement.

What do you think makes Augustine's conversion distinctively admirable compared to other forms of personal transformation? Is there something unique about religious conversion versus secular moral reform?

Consider that Augustine didn't just admit wrongdoing - he underwent a profound philosophical and spiritual transformation that changed his entire worldview. Does this depth of change factor into your assessment of why his conversion deserves admiration?

Emma April 6, 2025, 3:36 PM

I think that Augustine's conversion is particularly admirable because his life did not just change on the surface. He changed everything about what he thought, how he acted, how he treated others, and his relationship with God. I believe this is admirable because it takes a lot of internal work to achieve. I think some people solely admit their wrongdoings but do not do the work to completely transform their lives. Augustine did this, so this is why I think his conversion is admirable. What do you think about this? In your view, is this a more common thing that does not deserve as much recognition as it gets?

Owen April 7, 2025, 12:24 AM

Is a change admirable because it's a large change? Or because it is a difficult change? I'm not convinced that these are reasons why a change should be admirable. I think whether a change is admirable or not should be determined by the merits of the individual change. Even bad changes can be difficult to achieve but we don't consider them admirable. However, I understand that that doesn't apply here since Augustine's changes are good. So he changed to be good even though it was very difficult to do so. That is definitely admirable. But a difficult change for good doesn't have to involve God does it? Even if conversion is a lifelong process, he could admit his wrongdoings and transform his life without converting. What makes the conversion admirable as opposed to the specific act of confessing and transforming to be good? Unless you are stating that conversion is an act independent of God and anyone who admits to their wrongdoings and strives to change has converted?

Emma April 7, 2025, 1:45 PM

I definitely understand your argument that change, even change that is bad, is a big deal, but not admirable. I do not think that a difficult change for good has to involve God, but I think it is easier for people to turn away from their sinful actions with God's help. In my mind, I define conversion as the act of confessing and transforming to be good. After that, the lifelong process of continuing to do good thing and keep one's mindset on God (in Augustine's case) is just adding to the positive effects of the conversion. So, I do not think that this type of conversion could have been independent of God. Do you see conversion differently? Is there a way that someone could have a similar conversion to Augustine without God's help? Would that make their conversion less admirable?

Guide April 7, 2025, 1:45 PM

Owen, Emma raises an interesting question about the role of God in conversion.

Do you think there's something uniquely admirable about a transformation that involves spiritual surrender versus one based solely on personal willpower?

This gets at a deeper question: is Augustine's conversion admirable because of the difficulty of the change, or because of the specific nature of turning to God? Consider whether acknowledging a higher power might require a different kind of humility than secular self-improvement.

Owen April 8, 2025, 1:58 PM

I think that Augustine's conversion is admirable neither because of the difficulty of the change nor the specific nature of turning to God. I do think there is a way that someone could have a similar conversion to Augustine without God's help. Nor would it make their conversion any less admirable. I see conversion as the process by which he becomes a Christian. The lifelong process of continuing to do good things and keep one's mindset on God are independent things. In my view, the conversion has little to do with doing good

things. This is because Augustine does not begin doing good things because of the conversion, he undergoes the conversion because he wants to do good things. I take the Aristotelian view of someone who is virtuous being someone that performs virtuous acts habitually. A conversion, by my definition of a conversion, is not an act to be admired in and of itself.

Emma April 8, 2025, 2:54 PM

I understand your viewpoint, but I think I disagree with one of the things you said. When you said that conversion has little to do good things, I don't think I agree with this statement. It seems to be a common theme that people who convert do good things afterwards, even if they were not considered a "good person" beforehand. In my mind, a conversion causes people, including Augustine, to do good deeds, not the other way around. Do you think people can convert and do bad things as a result? Or can a conversion happen and not change one's actions at all?

Emma April 8, 2025, 2:58 PM

Also, you said that you see conversion as the process of becoming a Christian. Is there a way someone could do this without God's help? It's interesting to think about what might motivate someone who does not believe in God to convert to doing good deeds instead of bad. Do you have any thoughts as to what some possible motivations might be for this type of conversion? Would you consider this more admirable since the person is doing the work completely on their own, independent of God's help?

Owen April 9, 2025, 12:25 PM

I think the idea that people who convert do good things afterwards does not show that conversion causes one to do good deeds and is an instance of post hoc fallacy. I do think people can convert and still do bad things, just probably not as a result. I do think a conversion can happen and not change a person's actions at all. Whether there is a way someone could become a Christian without God's help is a difficult question to answer, but I don't think the answer should have any bearing on whether the conversion is admirable. This is because I don't think a conversion is any less admirable if done with God's help. I think it would help to define what should be admirable and what shouldn't be admirable to resolve this. I view something admirable as something that one should aspire to do. Perhaps this is why I disagree that the conversion is admirable. I don't aspire to convert, I do not believe in God, and yet I do believe in admitting wrongdoings and striving to do good deeds.

> **Guide** April 9, 2025, 12:25 PM
>
> Emma, Owen has raised an important philosophical question about what makes something admirable.
>
> **If admiration is tied to what we should aspire to do, how would you respond to someone who doesn't share Augustine's religious beliefs but still values moral improvement?**
>
> This gets at whether the religious dimension of Augustine's conversion is essential to its admirability, or if we can separate the moral transformation from its religious context. Is there something universally admirable in Augustine's story that transcends religious belief?

Emma April 9, 2025, 1:52 PM

In this case, I think you can separate the religious aspect of Augustine's conversion and just look at his moral improvements. I do not think the religious aspect is essential for admiring Augustine's conversion. If we remove this part completely, we can still look at the change in Augustine's thoughts, actions, and interactions with other people and admire that. While I personally think that the religious part is what sets Augustine's conversion apart from others in history with perhaps unreligious people, I think it is still possible to say that since people should aspire to do good things, we can admire this part of Augustine's character, making his conversion admirable. I think the general change in his character is what makes his conversion admirable, no matter what religious beliefs a person might have. Do you think that if we step away from the religious aspect of his conversion, it becomes easier to admire it since it is a more universal concept?

Understanding Quiz

Emma

What is Owen's main reason for not finding Augustine's conversion admirable?

Justification

- ✓ Owen believes Augustine's past sins cannot be undone by conversion.
- Owen thinks conversion is a superficial change.
- Owen believes conversion should be independent of religious beliefs.
- Owen thinks Augustine's conversion was not genuine.

How does Owen view the relationship between conversion and doing good deeds?

Justification

- Owen believes conversion directly leads to doing good deeds.
- Owen thinks conversion is unrelated to doing good deeds.
- ✓ Owen believes conversion is a result of wanting to do good deeds.
- Owen thinks conversion prevents people from doing good deeds.

What philosophical perspective does Owen use to evaluate conversion?

Justification

- Kantian ethics
- Utilitarianism
- ✓ Aristotelian virtue ethics
- Existentialism

What does Owen think about the role of God in conversion?

Justification

- Owen believes conversion must involve God to be admirable.
- ✓ Owen thinks conversion can happen without God's help.
- Owen believes conversion is only admirable with God's help.
- Owen thinks conversion is a purely religious act.

How does Owen define something as admirable?

Justification

- Something that is difficult to achieve.
- Something that involves religious transformation.
- ✓ Something that one should aspire to do.
- Something that results in public recognition.

Owen

What is Emma's main reason for finding Augustine's conversion admirable?

Justification

- Emma believes Augustine's conversion erased his past sins.
- ✓ Emma thinks Augustine's conversion shows humility and courage.
- Emma admires Augustine's teachings of celibacy and chastity.
- Emma believes Augustine's conversion was a cover-up for his past sins.

How does Emma view the process of conversion?

Justification

- As a single moment of becoming a Christian.
- ✓ As a lifelong endeavor of doing good and maintaining a relationship with God.
- As a way to erase past sins.
- As an act independent of God.

What does Emma believe about the role of God in conversion?

Justification

- Emma believes conversion can happen without God's help.
- ✓ Emma thinks conversion is easier with God's help.
- Emma believes conversion is solely based on personal willpower.
- Emma thinks conversion is an act independent of God.

According to Emma, what sets Augustine's conversion apart from other personal transformations?

Justification

- [x] The religious aspect of his conversion.
- The public nature of his conversion.
- The fact that he became a famous philosopher.
- The speed of his conversion.

How does Emma respond to the idea of separating the religious aspect from Augustine's conversion?

Justification

- Emma believes the religious aspect is essential for admiration.
- [x] Emma thinks the moral improvements can be admired separately from the religious...
- Emma believes separating the religious aspect makes the conversion less admirable.
- Emma thinks the religious aspect is the only admirable part of the conversion.

This thread was shared via Sway

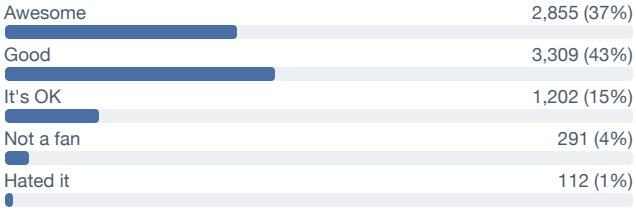
Platform-Wide Student Survey Data

Aggregated post-conversation survey responses, October 2024 – February 2026

281	1,750	7,900
ASSIGNMENTS	CHAT TOPICS	SURVEY RESPONSES

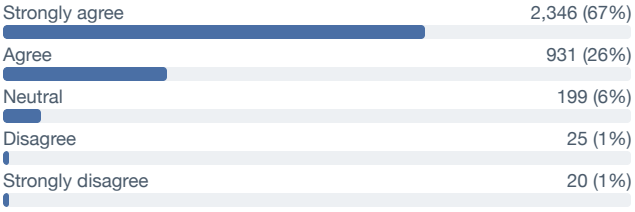
After each Sway conversation, students are encouraged to complete a short post-chat survey. Scale: −2 = Strongly disagree, 0 = Neutral, +2 = Strongly agree. Post-chat surveys sample a subset of the total survey items, so response counts vary across some items.

How was your chat?



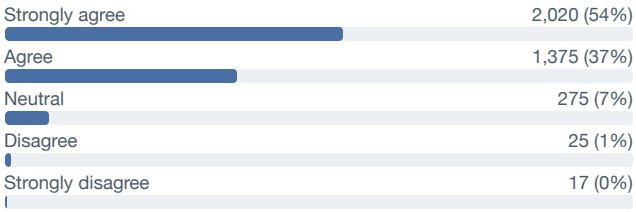
80% Awesome or Good · mean = 1.09 (95% CI: 1.07–1.11)

My partner was respectful



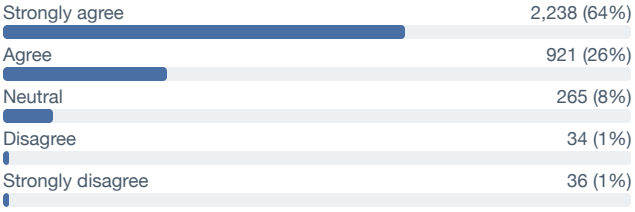
93% agree · mean = 1.58 (95% CI: 1.56–1.60)

I felt comfortable sharing my honest opinions with my partner



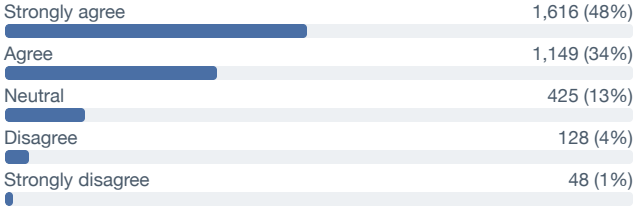
91% agree · mean = 1.44 (95% CI: 1.42–1.47)

I was not offended by my partner's perspective



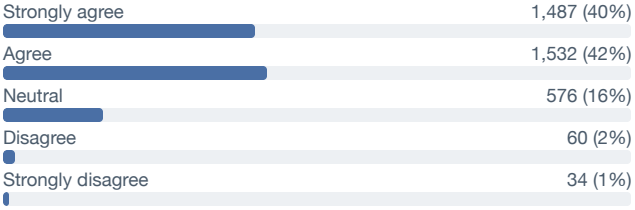
90% agree · mean = 1.51 (95% CI: 1.49–1.54)

My partner was genuinely trying to understand my perspective



82% agree · mean = 1.23 (95% CI: 1.20–1.27)

It was valuable to chat with a student who did not share my perspective

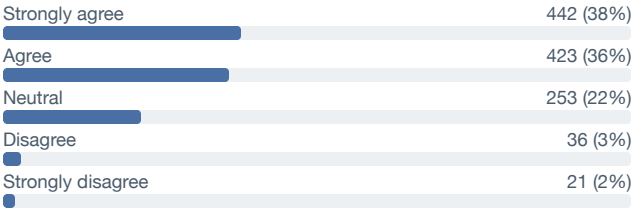


82% agree · mean = 1.19 (95% CI: 1.16–1.21)

My partner had better reasons for their views than I expected

59% agree · mean = 0.68 (95% CI: 0.65–0.71)

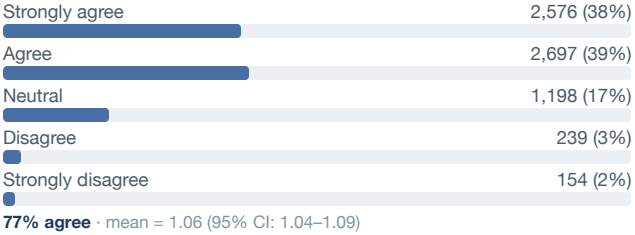
This discussion improved my perception of my partner



74% agree · mean = 1.05 (95% CI: 0.99–1.10)

This discussion led me to change my mind about something related to the topic

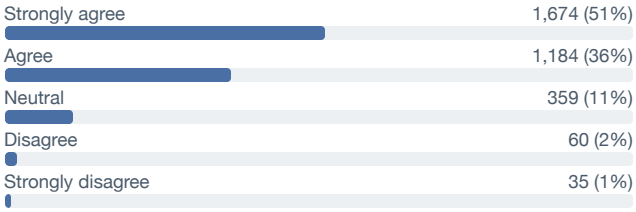
Guide's contributions improved the discussion



77% agree · mean = 1.06 (95% CI: 1.04–1.09)

42% agree · mean = 0.19 (95% CI: 0.13–0.24)

Guide treated me and my partner with equal respect



87% agree · mean = 1.33 (95% CI: 1.30–1.36)

These distributions reflect student experiences across diverse institutions, topics, and disciplines. The consistently high ratings for respect (93%), comfort sharing honest opinions (91%), low offense despite disagreement (90%), and genuine efforts to understand opposing perspectives (82%) suggest that structured disagreement can create conditions for intellectual virtue development at scale—while the AI facilitator's strong fairness ratings (87% equal respect) indicate that AI-guided dialogue need not come at the cost of impartiality.

Students Debate Evolution and Faith

Sample Instructor Report — Brigham Young University, Principles of Biology

At the conclusion of each Sway assignment, the platform automatically generates a comprehensive instructor report and delivers it to the course instructor. The report synthesizes data from all student conversations—including opinion distributions, thematic patterns, areas of agreement and persistent disagreement, the AI facilitator's role, and individual conversation summaries—giving instructors a detailed window into how their students engaged with the material.

The report below was generated for a Principles of Biology course at Brigham Young University in which students debated the relationship between evolutionary science and religious faith. Fourteen pairs of students were matched anonymously and guided through structured dialogue by Sway's AI discussion facilitator ("Guide"), which reads each conversation in real time and poses follow-up questions designed to deepen reasoning, surface assumptions, and push students past surface-level agreement. Students first registered their opinions on each topic (shown in the histograms below), then engaged in conversation with a peer who held a different view.

Discussion Topics

Evolution and Human Exceptionalism

"If humans evolved, that would mean humans are simply animals."

Evolution and Scientists vs Christians

"Scientists are generally antagonistic toward Christians."

Evolution Education as a Change in Worldview

"Learning about evolution has really been difficult and rocked my view of the world."

Evolution and Relationship with God

"Accepting human evolution would have impact on my relationship with God."

Evolution and the Plan of Salvation

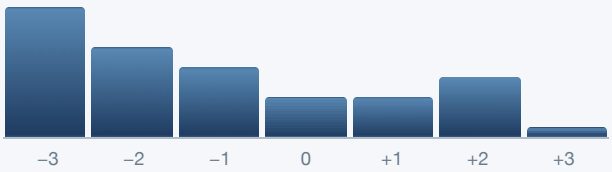
"Someone could accept human evolution and also accept all church doctrine."

Pre-Chat Opinion Distribution

Before their conversations, students rated their agreement with each topic statement on a 7-point scale (−3 = Strongly disagree to +3 = Strongly agree). Sway uses these opinions to match students who disagree.

Evolution and Human Exceptionalism

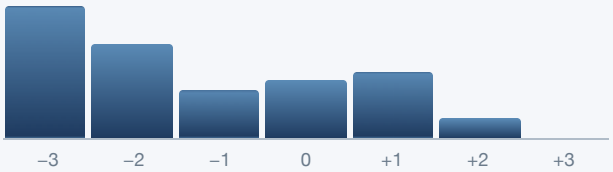
"If humans evolved, that would mean humans are simply animals."



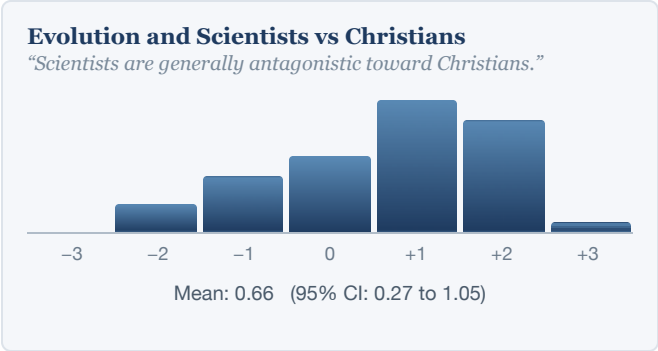
Mean: −1.02 (95% CI: −1.59 to −0.45)

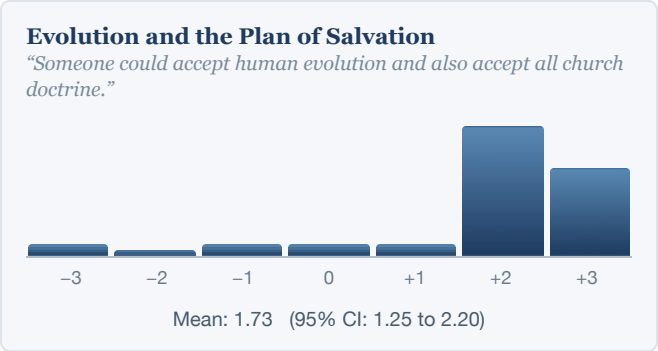
Evolution and Relationship with God

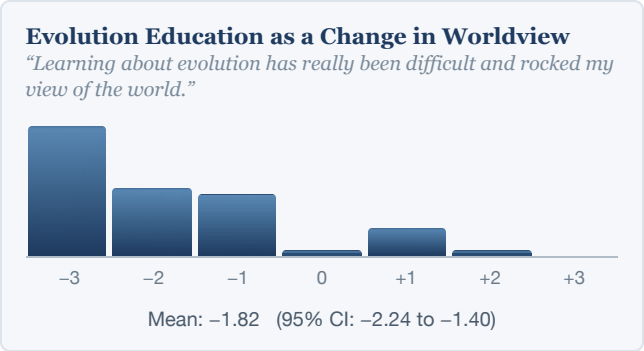
"Accepting human evolution would have impact on my relationship with God."



Mean: −1.27 (95% CI: −1.77 to −0.78)







Thematic Analysis

Students explored the intersection of human evolution with religious faith, debating whether evolutionary theory reduces humans to "simply animals" or conflicts with Christian doctrine. Across multiple conversations, students wrestled with reconciling scientific evidence of common descent with beliefs about humans as God's spirit children, the literal interpretation of Genesis, and whether the scientific community is antagonistic toward religious believers. The discussions revealed a campus community actively working to integrate scientific understanding with deeply held religious convictions, particularly within an LDS context.

Themes

- **Most students initially viewed evolution and religious doctrine as conflicting but discovered compatibility through reinterpretation.** One student explained how shifting from literal to interpretive scripture reading opened new possibilities: "evolution could be compatible with faith," though this shift made them wonder "what else in their beliefs might be open to reinterpretation."
- **The question of human exceptionalism dominated discussions, with students split between emphasizing biological continuity and spiritual uniqueness.** While some pointed to DNA similarity and shared survival instincts as evidence humans are "simply animals," others countered that consciousness, moral reasoning, and the capacity for "philosophical debates about their own nature" set humans fundamentally apart.
- **Students consistently moved from seeing scientist-Christian relations as antagonistic to recognizing indifference as more common.** Initial claims about scientists being hostile evolved into acknowledgment that science "sidelines religion by prioritizing empirical proof" rather than actively attacking it, with most agreeing that "indifference rather than hostility characterizes most scientific attitudes."

Guide's Role

- **Guide excelled at disrupting surface-level agreement by demanding specific evidence and deeper reasoning.** When students made broad claims about Christian scientists or evolutionary conflicts, Guide pressed them to "cite real-world examples" and articulate how their general assertions connected to concrete realities.

- **Guide consistently redirected abstract philosophical debates toward practical implications and personal stakes.** Rather than letting students float in theoretical space, Guide asked pointed questions like "If humans evolved and share common ancestry with other animals, why should being compared to animals be considered degrading?" forcing students to confront the ethical dimensions of their positions.

Common Ground

- **Students repeatedly discovered that accepting evolution need not undermine core religious faith when scripture is read non-literally.** Even those who initially saw "stark inconsistency" in Adam and Eve's creation eventually acknowledged that "evolution could be part of God's plan without undermining salvation theology."
- **Nearly all students agreed that human consciousness and abstract reasoning capabilities are extraordinarily advanced compared to other animals.** Even when debating whether these traits make humans fundamentally different, students acknowledged that "superior cognitive tools" and the ability to "question existence" are undeniably unique in degree if not in kind.

Persistent Disagreements

- **Students could not resolve whether human spiritual identity represents a real divine distinction or merely advanced cognition.** Some insisted humans are "God's spirit children" with souls that transcend biology, while others maintained that consciousness and morality are "just more complex versions" of animal cognition without requiring supernatural explanation.
- **The mechanics of reconciling Adam and Eve with evolution remained unresolved across discussions.** Students wrestled with questions about "Adam having non-human parents" and whether the rib-from-Adam story could coexist with common descent, with some calling these details "unknowable" mysteries while others saw them as fundamental contradictions.

Insights

- **Students often began discussions with firm positions but demonstrated remarkable intellectual flexibility through dialogue.** One participant who initially called evolution a "shelf item" later agreed it revealed "God's intricacy and love," while another who started by emphasizing irreconcilable differences admitted that "both views could coexist depending on interpretive priorities."

Conversation Summaries

Below are AI-generated summaries of all 14 conversations, organized by topic. Each summary captures key points of agreement and disagreement, and includes a representative prompt from the AI Guide showing how it steered the discussion toward deeper engagement. Student names have been redacted for privacy.

Evolution and Human Exceptionalism — 6 conversations

"If humans evolved, that would mean humans are simply animals."

- **Students grappled with whether evolution reduces humans to mere animals versus possessing unique spiritual and cognitive qualities.** Student 1 contended that humans are animals with heightened intelligence, while Student 2 countered that spiritual identity as God's children sets humans apart.
- **The debate evolved around defining exceptionalism through intelligence, consciousness, and morality.** Both acknowledged plausible points—intelligence as a matter of luck, consciousness hard to measure—and considered how moral responsibility and human rights hinge on perceived spiritual or cognitive uniqueness.
- **Guide consistently challenged students to justify how spiritual or intellectual traits carve a moral distinction if humans share common ancestry with animals.**

> **SAMPLE GUIDE PROMPT**
> *If humans evolved and share common ancestry with other animals, why should being compared to animals be considered degrading? What exactly makes animal-like treatment wrong if we are, biologically speaking, animals ourselves? Are you suggesting there's something fundamentally different about human consciousness that creates a moral distinction?*

- **Students explored whether evolution makes humans "simply animals," with Student 2 highlighting unique consciousness and moral reasoning while Student 1 initially invoked spiritual descent but then pointed to animal behaviors like penguin "gift-giving."** They moved from contrasting religious and secular views to a more nuanced debate on how ethics, sacrifice, and social bonds appear across species.
- **Guide steered the conversation by pressing students to define what truly sets humans apart and to address each other's objections directly.**

> **SAMPLE GUIDE PROMPT**
> *Student 1, how do you respond to Student 2's point about human consciousness and morality? He's suggesting these qualities make us more than simply animals even without invoking God. Does this align with your view about humans being God's spirit children, or do you see a fundamental difference in your reasoning?*

- **Students grappled with whether evolution reduces humans to "simply animals" by distinguishing biological commonalities from higher-level traits.** Student 2 emphasized shared evolutionary drives—need for food, survival instincts—and Student 1 countered that consciousness and agency set humans apart.
- **Discussion shifted when Student 2 introduced a religious dimension, asserting a spiritual purpose ordained by the Lord.** This addition broadened the debate from biological and philosophical grounds to include questions of spirituality and human exceptionalism.
- **Guide kept the conversation on track by redirecting off-topic requests, probing Student 2's reasoning, and inviting Student 1 to reconcile conscious agency with spiritual claims.**

> **SAMPLE GUIDE PROMPT**
> *Student 1, how do you respond to Student 2's point about humans being ordained for a higher purpose by the Lord? This seems to introduce a religious dimension that goes beyond your consciousness and agency argument. Does this spiritual component change how you think about the relationship between evolution and human nature?*

- **Students grappled with whether evolutionary lineage alone qualifies humans as animals or if our self-awareness sets us apart.** Student 1 emphasized shared ancestry and anatomical homologies to classify humans among animals, while Student 2 countered that our capacity for abstract thought and self-reflection elevates us beyond mere animals.
- **Guide persistently probed their definitions and pushed them to reconcile cognitive uniqueness with biological taxonomy.**

> **SAMPLE GUIDE PROMPT**
> *How do you respond to the idea that biological classification should be based on evolutionary relationships and physical structures rather than cognitive abilities? If we discovered another species with human-level intelligence, would that change your view about what makes something an "animal"?*

- **Students addressed whether evolution reduces humans to "simply animals," with Student 2 emphasizing shared ancestry and Student 1 invoking theological special creation.** They began with contrasting scientific and religious frames, each asserting a singular lens on human identity.
- **As the discussion unfolded, both parties softened their stances, acknowledging potential compatibility between evolution and spiritual significance.** Student 2 admitted oversight of the religious perspective, and Student 1 conceded that both views could coexist depending on interpretive priorities.
- **Guide prompted deeper engagement by steering students to question how evolutionary science and beliefs about divine image might intersect or conflict.**

> **SAMPLE GUIDE PROMPT**
> *Does accepting evolution necessarily conflict with the idea that humans might have special spiritual significance?*

- **Three students grappled with whether human evolution reduces humans to animals or if spiritual and cognitive uniqueness sets us apart.** Student 2, playing devil's advocate, leaned on DNA similarity and primal drives, while Students 1 and 3 contended that enhanced cognition and the idea of spirit children of God imply a deeper distinction.
- **Perspectives shifted as the limits of science and the notion of spirituality were weighed.** Student 1 admitted that science can't prove or disprove spiritual aspects, Student 2 acknowledged superior cognitive tools but rejected supernatural explanations, and Student 3 continued probing personal identity and shared human goals.
- **Guide persistently challenged assumptions by asking students to consider qualitative cognitive differences and the uniqueness of self-reflection.**

> **SAMPLE GUIDE PROMPT**
> *If you view yourself as just an animal, how do you explain your ability to have this very conversation? What other animals engage in philosophical debates about their own nature? The fact that you can question your own existence seems pretty unique.*

Evolution and Relationship with God — 3 conversations

"Accepting human evolution would have impact on my relationship with God."

- **Students began with opposing takes on evolution's impact but quickly found common ground that it enriches their understanding of God without changing their core faith.** Student 2 framed evolution as evidence of divine planning, while Student 1 initially called it a "shelf item," later agreeing it still reveals God's intricacy and love.
- **Guide pressed for clarity by asking them to unpack what "deepening understanding" means and whether understanding and relationship are distinct.**
- **The discussion stayed friendly and ended in unexpected consensus, with students joking about how hard it was to disagree.**

> **SAMPLE GUIDE PROMPT**
> *Student 2, wait — there's something interesting here. You initially said accepting evolution would impact your relationship with God, but now you're agreeing it doesn't affect the relationship, just your understanding. Are those actually the same thing or different? Can your understanding of God deepen without your relationship changing?*

- **Students grappled with whether accepting human evolution conflicts with a literal Genesis narrative, with Student 1 seeing a stark inconsistency in Adam and Eve's creation and Student 2 arguing for compatibility through divine guidance.** Student 1 pointed to the rib-from-Adam story as irreconcilable with common descent, while Student 2 maintained that evolution could be part of God's plan without undermining salvation theology.
- **Discussion evolved as Student 2 wrestled with questions about Adam's origins—even while asserting that evolution doesn't shake the "core" of faith.**

> **SAMPLE GUIDE PROMPT**
> *Student 2, you mentioned that evolution doesn't affect "the core of your faith" but then you're grappling with some pretty fundamental questions about Adam having non-human parents and what that means for humanity. How do you reconcile saying evolution doesn't impact your faith while simultaneously wrestling with whether Adam's parents were "fully human"?*

- **Students grappled with how accepting human evolution interfaces with their relationship with God, starting from opposing stances.** Student 1 felt evolution's timeline and a literal reading of "made in God's image" conflicted with church teachings, while Student 2 argued scripture doesn't specify the creation process, so evolution could fit.
- **Student 1 shifted from a literal to a more interpretive reading of scripture, acknowledging that evolution could be compatible with faith.** They reflected on how questioning linear interpretations made them wonder what else in their beliefs might be open to reinterpretation and deeper inquiry.
- **Guide fostered deeper analysis by challenging assumptions and prompting clarification on core tensions between scriptural literalism and interpretive flexibility.**

> **SAMPLE GUIDE PROMPT**
> *Student 1 seems to be describing a shift from literal to more interpretive reading of scripture which she says has changed her relationship with God. Do you think this kind of interpretive shift necessarily changes one's relationship with God, or could someone maintain the same relationship while adopting a less literal approach?*

Evolution and Scientists vs Christians — 3 conversations

"Scientists are generally antagonistic toward Christians."

- **Students began with opposing stances but quickly shifted toward a nuanced middle ground.** Student 1 originally argued that many scientific articles are authored by Christians to downplay hostility, while Student 2 countered that science often challenges religious beliefs, especially around evolution.
- **Student 1 leaned on anecdotal evidence of Christian scientists, and Student 2 stressed the "testing" tension between evolution and religion.** As Student 2 clarified how evolution can feel at odds with Christianity, Student 1 repeatedly agreed without detailing specific sources.
- **Guide persistently pressed for evidence and deeper reflection, urging both students to cite real-world examples.**

> **SAMPLE GUIDE PROMPT**
> *Student 1, how do you respond to Student 2's point about evolution and Christianity being difficult to reconcile? You initially mentioned reading articles by Christian scientists — do any of them address this apparent tension between evolutionary theory and religious belief?*

- **Students debated whether reported antipathy was specific to scientists or reflective of regional religious hostility.** Student 1 drew on two years of missionary service in Washington to claim scientists were antagonistic; Student 2 agreed the hostility exists but attributed it to regional culture rather than the scientific community broadly.
- **Guide pressed participants to distinguish anecdotal experiences from broader trends and to consider evidence criteria.**

> **SAMPLE GUIDE PROMPT**
> *How do you distinguish between regional hostility toward religion versus scientists specifically being antagonistic toward Christians? Could the pattern you observed reflect the culture in Washington rather than hint at a broader trend in the scientific community?*

- **Students initially clashed over whether scientists are generally antagonistic toward Christians, but gradually agreed that indifference rather than hostility characterizes most scientific attitudes.** Student 1 argued that science sidelines religion by prioritizing empirical proof, while Student 2 maintained that overt antagonism is rare, reframing the debate around relevance not hostility.
- **Guide steered the conversation with probing questions that clarified key distinctions and challenged assumptions.**

> **SAMPLE GUIDE PROMPT**
> *Student 2, you say it would be "fairly easy to disprove the idea of it being irrelevant to our mortal life." But if scientists are throwing Christianity to the wayside as irrelevant, and you think this view is easily disprovable, doesn't that suggest scientists are making a pretty significant error in their reasoning? How do you square that with your view that they're not antagonistic?*

Evolution and the Plan of Salvation — 1 conversation

"Someone could accept human evolution and also accept all church doctrine."

- **Students quickly aligned on accepting both human evolution and church doctrine, then shifted to unpacking lingering spiritual unknowns.** They referenced premortal spirits and the idea that God "stepped in" at a certain point in evolution, suggesting belief in a divine intervention layered on natural processes.
- **The chat oscillated between probing curiosity and lighthearted frustration, with students wondering if they just needed to chat for credit.** At times they felt Guide's questions were challenges or "attacks," yet they persisted in addressing how unknowable timing affects their confidence in reconciling faith and science.
- **Guide consistently pushed students to clarify and defend their assumptions, especially on spiritual uniqueness and reconciliation.**

> **SAMPLE GUIDE PROMPT**
> *Student 1, you said this timing question isn't something we'll understand until the afterlife. But if it's that unknowable, how can you be confident that evolution and church doctrine definitely can be reconciled? What makes you certain they fit together if the key details are mysteries?*

Evolution Education as a Change in Worldview — 1 conversation

"Learning about evolution has really been difficult and rocked my view of the world."

- **Students evaluated whether evolution education upends worldviews by pinpointing common descent, atavisms, and molecular homology as potentially "world-shaking."** Student 2 outlined how those concepts could unsettle learners, while Student 1 argued that evolution's logic provided clarity—though religious upbringing can add complexity.
- **Guide steered the dialogue by refocusing Student 2 on the core question and later challenging Student 1 to explore factors beyond faith that might make evolution troubling.**
- **Both students expressed awkwardness interacting with the AI moderator, highlighting a social barrier in AI-led discussions.** Their hesitation to engage Guide directly suggests varying comfort levels with technology-mediated learning environments.

> **SAMPLE GUIDE PROMPT**
> *Student 1, you said you can see how those concepts might be challenging, but you disagreed that learning evolution is difficult and world-rocking. What's your take on why some students might find common descent or molecular homology troubling, while you apparently didn't? Is it just about religious background, or are there other factors at play?*

Student Feedback Showcase

After every Sway discussion, students share their experiences through a post-chat survey. Their responses reveal how Sway creates space for constructive disagreement, encourages clear thinking and argumentation, and facilitates meaningful peer connections—even for students who usually keep quiet in traditional classrooms.

"

It encouraged me to think more critically and listen carefully to opposing viewpoints. The back- and-forth helped me practice explaining my reasoning respectfully and clearly, even when I disagreed. Overall, it made me feel more confident discussing complex issues because I realized productive dialogue isn't about winning an argument—it's about understanding perspectives and building thoughtful responses.

Building Confidence | Guided Chat

"

Guide's approach felt like an ideal classroom discussion: they asked thoughtful follow-up questions, encouraged nuance, challenged assumptions, and helped me reflect on my biases. It wasn't about getting the "right" answer, but about thinking critically and thoroughly exploring the topic.

Guided Chat | Classroom Comparison

"

I have never openly discussed immigration issues with a stranger. I felt comfortable given the time to come up with respectful arguments that gave good educated points rather than strongly heated opinions.

Building Confidence | Time to Think

"

It was much more civil, thought out, and logical! It felt like I was talking to another well-reasoned person rather than shouting against a brick-wall lol.

Classroom Comparison

"

Interestingly, we turned out to have the same view, we just expressed it slightly differently. I suppose a lesson I could learn from this is that although someone might be on the opposite side of an issue at the surface level, their underlying motivations could be the same as mine, which makes finding common ground even more important.

Common Ground | Changing Views

"

I liked conversing on Sway because it allowed me to actually read and internalized my partner's perspective. If we had been in person, I think I would have been less likely to listen as closely and more likely to focus on what I would say next. I also liked that guide was there to moderate. It gave me some good questions to think about that directly tied to what my partner and I were saying.

"

This Sway chat actually boosted my confidence in discussing complex issues with people who hold different views. Going back and forth with someone who defended egoism forced me to clarify my own reasoning, anticipate counterarguments, and respond more calmly and clearly. It showed me I can stay respectful and focused on ideas, not just opinions, which makes me feel much more capable of handling debates on tough topics.

"

Guide is very firm and direct and "all knowing" like my mom, sometimes making me nervous but honestly everyone needs something to ground them, this lil AI dude is growing on me even tho weve had our odds It helped me understand that even when someone disagrees with you, there are still fundamental truths that we can agree on to help establish a common ground.

Building Confidence | Guided Chat | Common Ground | Changing Views

"

It was very comforting to have a nice back and forth with someone despite our differences. It gave me confidence to try to find common ground with people I may think I disagree with. We likely have more in common than I'd realize!

Time to Think | Common Ground

"

I thoroughly enjoyed discussing different view points and found myself completely immersed in their side. Our chat was straightforward and clear, allowing me to clearly understand the other viewpoints to the issue. By the end of it, I found myself agreeing with a lot of ideas my partner expressed.

Building Confidence | Guided Chat | Common Ground | Changing Views

"

i felt very confident in my argument and i didn't feel the need to shy away or hide my opinion because i felt like it was a safe space even though we disagreed.

Building Confidence

"

It helped me test my own reasoning and find weak points in my own arguments. It also helped me review what is being said by being able to slow their argument down since its a chat therefore allowing me to make a sure I address every question and concern that was brought up. Overall it felt extremely productive.

Time to Think | Guided Chat

"

We had guide to help probe us and make us think deeper. It is easy to fall into group think, but guide helped challenge us and helped us to see different aspects of the conversation than we ever would have thought of on our own, and you don't get that in a classroom setting.

Classroom Comparison

“

Gave me a safe space to refute, ask questions and express any confusion or ideas I had without judgement or tension. As well as facilitate further research and hearing a different point of view which resulted in more learning and understanding.

Building Confidence | Time to Think | Changing Views

“

It definitely increased my confidence. Hearing [my partner]'s challenges helped me think more critically about my own arguments and express them more clearly. I feel more prepared now to have respectful discussions on difficult topics with people who disagree with me.

Building Confidence

“

It was awesome! I loved having time to think about my response and thoroughly understand my partner's. That isn't as easy in person and often there isn't enough time for this in class.

Building Confidence | Classroom Comparison | Time to Think

“

The chat was engaging and made me think more deeply about different perspectives on ethical egoism. I loved being able to see both sides of the argument and understand how self-interest can be viewed in both positive and negative ways.

Building Confidence | Time to Think | Changing Views

“

I honestly think it increased my confidence in discussing complex issues. The notes Guide gave [my partner] conveyed to me that it's important to be wary of the language one uses in discussing to avoid broad generalizations.

Building Confidence | Guided Chat

“

I think completing this Sway Chat improved my confidence in discussing complex issues with people who hold differing opinions significantly, as it forced me to speak my mind, hold my ground, and respond to opposing views with tact.

Building Confidence

“

I definitely found myself questioning my original statement and my confidence was negatively affected. However, getting to discuss important topics like feminism with guide’s question really made me think and helped me see my classmates perspective in the end.

Changing Views

“

I felt more open to expressing myself freely than I would've speaking out loud in the classroom. My chat partner was very respectful, which also helped with this. I also think writing down my answers allowed me to review and refine them before sharing, which helped my answers reflect my feelings more truly.

Building Confidence | Time to Think

“

I loved practicing rephrasing their response and adding a comment to it, including a personal experience. This has been so cool to see how we could connect and agree on the foundational virtues that we both value.

Building Confidence | Common Ground

“

Having to play Devil's advocate forced me to think about the arguments that could be presented by the other side and assess their validity. The difficulty I had in coming up with arguments for the other side reinforced my confidence in my original opinion.

Changing Views

“

it allowed me to gain confidence in discussing complex issues with people who hold different views from me, it also allowed me to gain a wider perspective and be more open to listening and acknowledging opposing views.

Changing Views

“

I liked Guide’s approach a lot! It helped me think more about both the pros and cons of de-extinction in a way that felt organized and easy to follow. The questions helped keep the conversation on track and made me go deeper with my answers. It actually felt more focused than some classroom discussions where people don’t always stay on topic or everyone doesn’t get to speak.

Common Ground | Changing Views | Guided Chat

“

Guide is a cool AI that is able to synthesize points and challenge each party separately. I also like that you can ask guide mid conversation what similarities of opinion and differences it picks up on to keep diving deeper into discussion. Fascinating experience that could very well help people in communication.

Guided Chat

“

I think that Sway allowed me to talk people in my class that I would not normally have a discussion with. I liked chatting with [my partner] because he had a different perspective on this topic than I did and it was interesting to talk about it. Also, I think that it gave me a better perspective on the topic.

Classroom Comparison | Common Ground | Changing Views

“

I feel that using this system has actually allowed me and a partner to have a meaningful, guided discussion. In class, the topic of conversation and the discussion are short, and I don't tend to learn much about others' opinions. This was my first time using this system, but I enjoyed it.

Guided Chat | Classroom Comparison

“

I really liked my discussion. Both sides were willing, and the best thing about the discussion taking place on Sway is that you have to think before you type your response. I feel many people forget to do this in discussions that take place in person, even in classroom discussions.

Time to Think

“

I liked how Guide opened up the conversation by asking us to expound more on our opinions given specific scenarios. Guide helped me realize that there is more to the issue than what I know, which I appreciated because it helped me rethink my opinion on the issue.

Classroom Comparison | Guided Chat | Changing Views

“

It helped me understand and analyze other perspectives. Responding in a critical way to different perspective helped me gain additional understanding and emotional maturity when it comes to having important discussions with others.

Classroom Comparison | Building Confidence

“

Talking on Sway feels more comfortable and inclusive than classroom discussions. It lets me express my thoughts at my own pace, though I do sometimes miss the energy of live conversation. Overall, it’s a great platform for thoughtful participation.

Changing Views | Classroom Comparison

“

Challenged me to see the viewpoint of the other side of the argument and made me realize that there can be many pros to the other side of an argument

Common Ground | Changing Views

“

It felt nice to discuss a topic with a dissenting opinion. I was able to find both the positives and the negatives of space exploration, and the conversation greatly helped me clarify and better understand my own position.

Common Ground | Changing Views

“

I really liked how the guide asked us to elaborate on certain points we made or challenged us to consider the other persons perspective in a different way! The guide was a lot more active and helpful than I thought it would be!

Changing Views

“

Guide's approach was kind of like a classroom discussion, but more direct and structured. It made me think deeper and actually respond to challenges instead of just repeating my point.

Classroom Comparison

“

Helped me learn opposing views and reasons. I like how Sway broke down important parts of our arguments and asked us about them because we may have overlooked it

Guided Chat | Changing Views

“

I appreciate how approaching discussions online lets me more carefully consider my responses before posting them. Although this is a nice feature, I also believe that being able to manage the pressure of face-to-face discussions is an invaluable skill to develop. So, I'd personally recommend using Guide in conjunction with classroom discussions whenever possible.

Classroom Comparison

“

I love how Guide hears both my opinions and my partner's while allowing us to dive deeper into the conversation, which is often missed in class. It helped me put my opponents arguments into simple points so that I could come up with good counterarguments.

Guided Chat | Classroom Comparison

“

Guide was extremely unbiased and posed questions to both of us using details we incorporated in out arguments. It challenged us to elaborate on weaker links so we can strengthen connection between premises. I feel classroom discussions can be more biased and prone to a heated argument ensuing. Specifically by observing someone's body language, tone of voice, and word choices.

“

I think that it was more peaceful and direct. I also appreciate being able to go back and read what was previously said and having the Guide there to provide context and prompts. At one point, the Guide prompted us to define the boundary between hate speech and extremism, which was something we could both agree on.

“

It was nice to have a space to hold a conversation; even though we didn’t *actually* disagree on the initial statement, I enjoyed sharing on points where we didn’t necessarily align. I found myself agreeing with some of his points, which was surprising considering how polarizing conversations about women’s rights can become.

Common Ground

“

Guide was extremely helpful in grounding me. I would not be able to find mistake in my slippery slope or consider my stance in a much deeper perspective.

Changing Views

“

Guide helps the conversation flow when misunderstandings or loss of ideas arise. In the classroom, we sit in silence when we don’t understand or have nothing to add.

Classroom Comparison

“

I enjoyed chat guidance. I have horrible ADHD and can connect off topic comments and it kept me on track.

Accessibility | Building Confidence

Sway News & Recognition

Over the past year, Sway has evolved from a Carnegie Mellon research project into a globally recognized platform for constructive student dialogue—featured in congressional testimony, covered by national media, and adopted at over 80 colleges and universities.

HIGHLIGHTS

FEDERAL GRANT
$4M Dept. of Education FIPSE Grant

AWARD WINNER
Learning Engineering Tools Competition 2025

MAJOR GRANT
$341,647 from Arthur Vining Davis Foundations

CONGRESSIONAL TESTIMONY
U.S. Senate HELP Committee

SUPPORTED BY

heterodox academy · The Learning Agency · The Snider Foundation · Carnegie Mellon University · The Arthur Vining Davis Foundations · Ben Delo Foundation · Omidyar Network

AWARDS & RECOGNITION

GRANT

U.S. Department of Education FIPSE Grant

Sway is a key partner in a $4 million grant awarded to the University of Notre Dame and North Carolina State University through the Department of Education's $60 million Civil Discourse priority. The four-year "Integrating Civil Discourse into the Curriculum" (ICDC) initiative—a partnership between Notre Dame, NC State, the School of Civic Life and Leadership at UNC-Chapel Hill, Disagree Wisely, Heterodox Academy, and ThinkerAnalytix—will train nearly 48,000 students on Sway and 375 faculty members across 125 campuses, including R1 universities, HBCUs, and community colleges.

WINNER

Learning Engineering Tools Competition 2025

Selected from over 1,000 entries as one of six winners in the world's largest ed-tech competition, which "supports learning tools and platforms that promise to transform education and enhance student engagement worldwide."

GRANT

Arthur Vining Davis Foundations Grant

A $341,647 grant to scale Sway across higher education—supporting deployment to 10,000+ students at dozens of institutions, app development, empirical research on depolarization, and disseminating best practices for classroom and co-curricular settings.

CONGRESSIONAL TESTIMONY

U.S. Senate HELP Committee: Antisemitic Disruptions on Campus

Sway was cited as a positive example of an educational tool that can improve campus climate and teach students constructive disagreement. Kenneth Stern, director of Bard's Center for the Study of Hate, described Sway in his expert testimony:

> *Last year two academics from Carnegie Mellon launched [Sway]. It's like John Stuart Mill on AI. No raised voices, no eye rolls, just text back and forth. Sway's AI recognizes when students are engaging in ad hominem attacks, and gives them suggestions of other ways to phrase their points. It asks for examples. And it's fun.*
>
> *Further, one of the challenges on campus is that too many students are afraid to say what they think. This long predated the attacks of October 7, and goes far beyond the issues of Israel and Palestine. But Sway actually creates an opportunity for these discussions without any of the fears of sacrificing a friendship or being ostracized by peers.*

WINNER

Heterodox Academy Open Inquiry Award (Teaching)

Simon Cullen received HxA's Open Inquiry Award for Teaching Excellence, recognizing him for "helping to develop and popularize pedagogical techniques that can promote open, rigorous, and challenging classroom inquiry."

MEDIA COVERAGE

CHRONICLE OF HIGHER EDUCATION

Can an AI Tool Help Students Disagree Better?

In-depth feature profiling Sway's growth from research project to nationwide tool. Professors from UCLA, UPenn, and Fullerton College describe transformed classroom dynamics. Full article reprinted in the following section.

NBC NEWS

Agree to Disagree: How Chat Platforms and AI Could Transform Campus Debates

National feature with professors describing classrooms where students "feel comfortable to ask questions, to get things wrong, to make mistakes, to learn from each other."

INSIDE HIGHER ED

'Weaponizing Antisemitism': Campus Speech Under Siege

Kenneth Stern (Bard Center for the Study of Hate) recommends Sway for fostering "intellectual curiosity and emotional empathy" to help "tamp down an environment where hate might emerge."

UCLA NEWSROOM

How to Help Students Have Difficult Conversations in the Classroom

Sociology professor Abigail Saguy describes Sway as creating "brave spaces" where students develop "higher tolerance for discomfort" and deeper appreciation of their chat partner's perspectives.

EDSCOOP

Universities Test AI as Debate Aid for Controversial Topics

Thousands of students using Sway as a mediator for constructive conversations on racism, immigration, and Israel—deescalating tension and helping with phrasing.

INQUISITIVE MAGAZINE

The Forbidden Fruit of Uncomfortable Ideas

Barbara Oakley calls Sway "cognitive cross-training"—"the goal isn't persuasion; it's perception, improving your own thinking while truly grasping an opposing stance."

HETERODOX ACADEMY

This Game-Changing AI Tool Helps Students Learn Constructive Disagreement

Alice Dreger on how Sway helps students "speak and listen in more respectful, productive ways" by scaffolding reasoning and detecting unconstructive messages.

GERSTELL ACADEMY

Ethics Students Use AI to Strengthen Civil Discourse and Critical Thinking

One of the first high schools to deploy Sway in Applied Ethics classes. 72% of students strongly agreed their partner had better reasons for their views than expected.

THE CHRONICLE
OF HIGHER EDUCATION

MACHINE MEDIATION

Can an AI Tool Help Students Disagree Better?

By Aisha Baiocchi

January 30, 2026

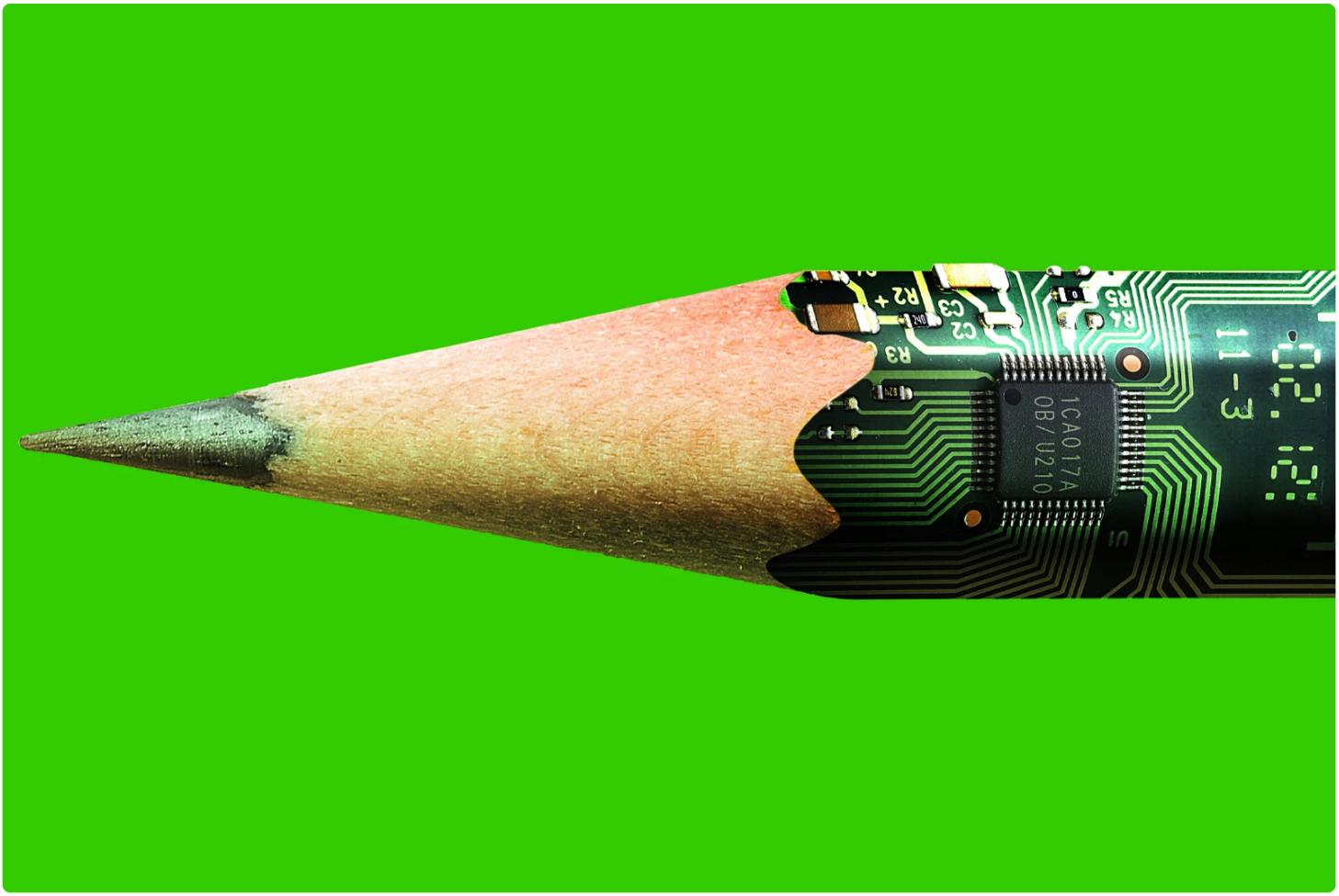


ILLUSTRATION BY THE CHRONICLE; GETTY

Abigail Saguy, a professor of sociology at the University of California at Los Angeles, was a little bit nervous to teach a course called "Sociology of Gender" again. She'd last done so in 2019, and found the atmosphere increasingly combative, saying student activists in her course had attempted to "police" her readings and word choice. So in 2024 she tried something new: She got students to debate each other virtually, using a new tool called Sway.

Saguy was the first professor to use the tool, which has now been used at 78 colleges and a handful of high schools. It was designed by two scholars who study disagreement, and combines two of the hottest trends in academe today: artificial intelligence and civil discourse. It has also attracted federal investment. Institutes at the University of Notre Dame and the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill were recently awarded nearly $4 million in grant funding to expand the use of Sway, among other things.

Here's how Sway works. An instructor selects a prompt, usually a controversial statement. (Simon Cullen, one of the tool's creators, said gender is by far the most popular topic with prompts ranging from the ethics of abortion to transgender athletes.) Students rate how much they agree or disagree with the prompt, and then are matched with opposing viewpoints for a virtual chat. Users provide a display name but are not required to identify themselves or use their actual names. During the discussion, the AI tool intervenes with suggestions that the creators say are to ensure the conversation is as productive as possible.

For example: In a discussion about abortion, if you were to type something accusatory about your debate partner's opinion on women, Sway might tell you to address your partner's reasoning instead of speculating on their motives. It also asks guiding questions, trying to refocus argument away from what it interprets as accusations or

slogans.

“The bulk of what the AI is doing is actually argumentation,” said Cullen, a faculty research fellow at the Heterodox Academy’s Segal Center for Academic Pluralism and a visiting research professor at UNC-Chapel Hill. “And trying to understand, are we really connecting with each other? Are we all using words in the same way? And then, what is the argument? Where do we disagree? Let’s isolate our disagreement, then let’s try and understand what the evidence is for and against it.”

Cullen and his Sway co-creator, Nicholas DiBella, who also holds a position at Heterodox, trained the AI by feeding it thousands of messages with arguments and classifying them manually. DiBella said they determined what arguments were constructive, which were redeemable with some edits, and which were unacceptable.

NEWSLETTERS

Afternoon Update

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As such, the AI tool reflects its two creators’ understanding of what is, and isn’t, a productive argument. Cullen said there is an element of subjectivity to Sway’s design, but because it is a machine-learning model, it is consistent in how it applies their principles. He acknowledged that two different scholars would likely develop a different tool with different principles, but he finds Sway to be effective for its purpose.

The idea of a machine mediating intellectual debate is a little eerie to some. But many professors who have used Sway have found it helpful. Saguy of UCLA has used it for homework assignments before beginning a new unit, and said she found that students came to class more engaged and willing to debate constructively.

Patrick Ryan, a philosophy professor at Fullerton College, in California, said the tool completely changed the way he taught virtual classes, which he used to dread. Students in Ryan's asynchronous "Introduction to Ethics" course began units with discussions of 35 to 45 minutes on Sway, which they then wrote reports on afterward. Fullerton is a Hispanic-serving institution, and Ryan said he was cautious about asking students for their personal views on certain topics because he worried "emotional distress" could hinder learning. He used Sway to debate broader topics like the right to immigrate for a better life, finding that most students were sensitive to their peers while using Sway to debate, often changing their minds.

Ryan described himself as "deeply skeptical" of generative AI, especially in an educational context. He said he finds Sway useful because he thinks it's been trained well, and he's been able to use it to push student thinking in ways he can't because of his own limited time.

"I'm not terribly worried about it, because I see it being an imperfect tool that's going to get things going," said Ryan. "It's going to keep the conversations on the rails — that's a big thing too, because I can't monitor everything."

In her freshman seminar on disagreement, Diana Mutz, a professor of political science at the University of Pennsylvania, partnered with professors at other universities to have her students debate their counterparts on other campuses.

Mutz said she did so because she wanted to expose her students to a range of opinions,

and because it would be difficult to achieve anonymity in such a small course. The students debated topics ranging from Palestine to cancel culture, and she said her students got increasingly confident in their ability to voice their opinions.

While civil discourse is a buzzy concept in higher education today, Mutz said she finds most discourse initiatives rely too much on facilitation and don't actually give students the tools to disagree productively. "I study democratic pluralism, and you know what? We're just not gonna have that about everything. And I think that's OK. It's just we have to figure out a way to move forward when we don't have consensus." Sway, she said, is a way of showing students how to do that.

The tool is still relatively new, so its creators can't quantify its efficacy yet. Users can opt to submit transcripts of their chats to the nonprofit that houses Sway for analysis, and the reports have been positive, its creators said.

The tool's growing prominence has touched off concerns. In an opinion article in *The Chronicle Review*, Hollis Robbins, a University of Utah professor, raised alarms about the tool's potential for abuse of student data. Cullen and DiBella responded by saying that professors do not have access to student opinions or conversations. They are provided with instructor reports, which generate data about the conversations in the class, but no student names or other identifying information are included.

Sway's creators are looking to expand. The new federal money will allow them to better measure how well it's working, Cullen said, and he hopes Sway can grow to reach larger audiences, like becoming a part of campus orientations: "I can't think of a better way to start your university education than having a fantastic discussion with someone you disagree with about something that matters."

We welcome your thoughts and questions about this article. Please email the editors or submit a

letter for publication.

Tags Technology

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About the Author

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Aisha Baiocchi is a reporting fellow at *The Chronicle.* She was previously a reporter for the *Tampa Bay Times* and served as special-projects editor for *The Daily Tar Heel,* the UNC's student paper. You can follow her on X at @_aishabee_.

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Sway Across the Curriculum & Across Institutions

From Ivy League to community colleges, HBCUs to international universities — www.swaybeta.ai

Sway has grown almost entirely through word of mouth, without a sales or marketing team. The result is a deployment footprint that spans institutional types, academic disciplines, and nine countries—with demand accelerating.

80+	8,500+	9	$4M
COLLEGES & UNIVERSITIES	COLLEGE & UNIVERSITY STUDENTS	COUNTRIES	FIPSE GRANT (125 CAMPUSES)

Where Students Have Used Sway

Over 80 colleges and universities have deployed Sway in courses, with more than 8,500 students completing structured dialogues across genuine disagreements. The institutions below represent a cross-section of this deployment—from Ivy League to community colleges, research universities to religiously affiliated schools.

IVY LEAGUE & ELITE PRIVATE

Harvard, U Penn, Stanford, Carnegie Mellon, Northwestern, U Miami

R1 PUBLIC RESEARCH UNIVERSITIES

UCLA, UC Santa Barbara, U Washington, Virginia Tech, Georgia State, Michigan State, Ohio State, NC State, Purdue, Indiana U

ADDITIONAL R1/R2 PUBLIC

Arizona State, UNC Chapel Hill, UNC Charlotte, U Delaware, U Georgia, U Nebraska–Lincoln, Oregon State, U Alabama, Old Dominion, U Rhode Island

SELECTIVE LIBERAL ARTS

Swarthmore, Carleton, Bowdoin, Pomona, Scripps, Pitzer, Hobart & William Smith, Providence

HBCU

North Carolina Central University

HISPANIC-SERVING INSTITUTIONS

CSU Fullerton, CSU Long Beach, CSU Chico, Arizona State, U Miami

COMMUNITY & TWO-YEAR COLLEGES

Community College of Baltimore County, Fullerton College, Glen Oaks CC, Iowa Western CC

REGIONAL & MID-SIZE UNIVERSITIES

Grand Valley State, Duquesne, Brescia, Mount Mercy, Hawai'i Pacific, Sonoma State, Simpson, U West Florida, Saint Louis U, U Cincinnati

RELIGIOUSLY AFFILIATED

Brigham Young U, BYU-Idaho, Providence, Duquesne, Texas Christian, U St. Thomas, Simpson

PROFESSIONAL SCHOOLS

U Miami (Medicine), U Toronto (Pharmacy), Rutgers (Psych. Rehab.), Rocky Mountain (SLP), U Cincinnati (Law/Mediation)

International Reach — 9 Countries

Beyond the United States, Sway has been adopted at institutions in eight additional countries.

Canada
U Toronto, UBC, Simon Fraser, U Ottawa, Douglas, Fanshawe, Lethbridge Polytechnic

United Kingdom
U Worcester, University College London

Germany
TH Wildau, U Bayreuth

Spain
Pompeu Fabra University

Australia
U Queensland, Macquarie U

South Africa
U Cape Town

India
Ambedkar U Delhi

Lebanon
Lebanese American U

Sway is also used in Coursera courses, whose students span additional countries not reflected in the count above.

Academic Disciplines

Constructive disagreement is not discipline-specific. Instructors have integrated Sway into courses ranging from philosophy and political science to biology, nursing, and engineering.

Philosophy & Ethics *Critical thinking, environmental ethics, computer ethics*	**Political Science** *Political theory, policy, political psychology*	**Psychology** *Behavioral science, social psychology, gender*
Sociology & Gender *Race, inequality, pop culture, feminism*	**Communication** *Argumentation, business writing, research methods*	**Biology & STEM** *Conservation, evolution, AI, nutrition policy*
Health Sciences *Medicine, pharmacy, psychiatric rehab, SLP*	**Education** *Ed admin, AI literacy, teaching seminars*	**Dialogue & Conflict** *Civil discourse, mediation, peace studies*

Upcoming Adoption

Instructors at more than 100 additional colleges and universities across five new countries have already signed up to use Sway in their courses through the rest of 2026, including Columbia, MIT, Howard University, Georgetown Law, Baylor, the University of Michigan, and Cambridge Muslim College. Beyond individual courses, we are in discussions with several universities about incorporating Sway into orientation programming and general education requirements. Separately, a $4 million FIPSE grant (U.S. Department of Education) will deploy Sway across a 125-campus consortium by 2029, with structured research on learning outcomes built into the rollout.